



RELIGION AND ETHICS

Student's book



Senior Two

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FOREWORD

Dear Student,

The Rwanda Basic Education Board (REB) is honoured to present Religion and Ethics Senior Two. This textbook is designed to support effective implementation of the Competence-Based Curriculum (CBC), ensuring learner-centred teaching practices that align with Rwanda's vision of empowering learners to reach their full potential, actively participate in society, and pursue meaningful careers.

As Rwanda advances towards building a knowledge-based economy, education plays a pivotal role. Teachers are central to this transformation, guiding learners to connect classroom knowledge with real-life experiences, thus fostering individual growth and national development. This learner's book serves as a comprehensive resource for teaching Religion and Ethics Senior Two. The subject is an integral part of the CBC, aimed at equipping learners with essential knowledge, skills, values, and attitudes necessary for becoming responsible and competent citizens. Through this subject, learners are encouraged to develop problem-solving abilities and contribute positively to their communities.

In pursuit of quality education, the Government of Rwanda emphasizes the importance of using teaching and learning materials that are aligned with the curriculum. I sincerely thank everyone who contributed to the refinement of this textbook.

Special recognition goes to the REB team, who coordinated the entire process. We thank all partners, teachers, and individuals who were involved in the process from the start to the end. Every piece of feedback was highly valued and helped to improve the learning outcomes of our learners.



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UNIT I:

ATTRIBUTES OF GOD

Key unit competence

A learner will be able to analyse and appreciate the key attributes of God to deepen their trust in Him.

Learning outcomes

By the end of the unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Explain the meaning of "attributes of God."
- Identify different attributes of God as revealed in the Qur'an and the Bible.
- Explain the concept of the Oneness of God and God's eternity.
- Explain the meanings of God's mercy and justice.

Skills

- Identify different attributes of God from the Scriptures.
- Identify examples of God's power and knowledge in the world.
- Compare how mercy and justice operate together in God's dealings with mankind.

Attitude and values

- Appreciate the uniqueness and perfection of God and show respect in worship and daily life.
- Develop unwavering faith in one God; appreciate God's eternal.
- Develop trust in God's wisdom and capabilities; recognise human limitations.

INTRODUCTION

In this unit, we will explore the attributes of God and their significance across various scriptures. We will learn about the qualities of God and why they are important in different holy books. We will look at God's oneness, eternity, mercy, and justice as shown in the Bible, the Qur'an, and the Hadith. Students will find examples of God's power and knowledge in the world and see how mercy and justice work together in God's actions. The goal of this unit is to help students appreciate God's perfection, grow stronger in faith in one God, and trust His wisdom while understanding that humans have limits.



Introductory activity

A Rwandan teacher came into the classroom to check attendance. The first fifteen students had names with special meanings that Rwandans believed in one God:

Kinyarwanda names	Their meaning
Irihariye	He is unique
Mpuhwezimana	God's mercy
Irera	He is holy
Rugira	The owner of all
Iyakaremye	The Creator
Niyokwizerwa	He is trustworthy
Niyobuhungiro	He is the refuge
Uhoraho	Eternal, immortal
Iratuzi	He knows us completely
Iradukunda	He loves us unconditionally
Itwitaho	He cares for us
Ntihemuka	He is loyal and faithful
Ibeshaho	We depend on Him
Irihariye	He is unique
Ntindhuka	He is always the same

Looking at these names and their meanings, what do they teach us about who God is, and how can these attributes inspire the way we live together in Rwanda today? Discuss in pairs.

1.1 Meaning and importance of God's attributes



Learning activity 1.1

Observe the image above and answer the questions that follow:



1. What event is happening in the picture?
2. Is this normal event, or is it a miracle?
3. From this event, which attribute of God can you see?
4. What do you understand by the term "Attributes of God"?
5. Give one quality that both God and people share, and one quality that belongs only to God.

1.1.1 Meaning of attributes of God

a) Attribute: An attribute is a quality or characteristic used to describe a person or thing.

b) Attributes of God: Attributes of God are the qualities people use to describe who God is and what He can do. We cannot see God with our eyes, and our human minds cannot fully understand Him (God is transcendent). But through His great power and miracles, people describe Him and feel His presence close to them (God is immanent).

Examples of God's attributes:

- Omnipotent (all-powerful)
- Almighty
- Omniscient (all-knowing)
- Independent
- Self-existent
- Love
- Immutable (unchanging)
- Holy
- Immortal
- Infinite
- Omnipresent (present everywhere)
- Merciful
- Powerful
- Infallible (never makes mistakes)
- Kind and tolerant
- Wise

1.1.2 Categories of the attributes of God

1. Major Attributes

a) Omnipotent (All-Powerful)

Omnipotent (All-Powerful): God is described as omnipotent, meaning He has unlimited power and nothing is impossible for Him. This attribute shows that God is the creator and sustainer of all things, and His authority extends over the entire universe. The Bible affirms this in Genesis 1:1, which states, "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth," highlighting His supreme creative power. Similarly, the Qur'an emphasizes God's limitless ability in Surah Al-Baqarah 2:20, declaring, "Indeed, Allah is over all things competent." Both scriptures agree that God's omnipotence assures believers of His ability to protect, guide, and accomplish His will in every situation.

b) Omniscient (All-Knowing)

God is omniscient, meaning He has complete and perfect knowledge of everything. Nothing is hidden from Him, including human thoughts, actions, and intentions. This attribute assures believers that God understands their needs and guides them with wisdom. The Bible emphasizes this in Jeremiah 1:5, where God says, "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you," showing His knowledge of human life even before birth. Similarly, the Qur'an highlights God's infinite knowledge in Surah Al-An'am 6:59: "And with Him are the keys of the unseen; none knows them except Him." Both scriptures affirm that God's omniscience gives believers confidence to trust Him fully, knowing that He sees and understands all things.

c) Omnipresent (Present Everywhere)

God is omnipresent, meaning He is present everywhere at all the times and no one can hide from Him. This attribute shows that God is not limited by space or time, and His presence brings comfort and guidance to believers wherever they are. The Bible expresses this in Psalm 139:7–10, asking, "Where can I go from your Spirit? Where can I flee from your presence?" reminding Christians that God's presence is constant and inescapable. Likewise, the Qur'an affirms this truth in Surah Al-Hadid 57:4: "And He is with you wherever you are," assuring Muslims that Allah is always near to guide and protect them. Both scriptures highlight that God's omnipresence gives believers confidence, peace, and assurance that they are never alone.

d) Holy (Pure and Perfect)

God's holiness means that He is completely pure, free from sin, and morally perfect. This attribute sets Him apart from all creation and makes Him the ultimate standard of righteousness. Believers are called to reflect on this holiness in their own lives by living in purity, obedience, and integrity. The Bible emphasizes this in 1 Peter 1:16, which says, "Be holy, because I am holy," reminding Christians that holiness is both God's nature and a command for His people. Likewise, the Qur'an highlights God's holiness in Surah Al-Jumu'ah 62:1: "Whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth exalts Allah, the Sovereign, the Pure, the Exalted in Might, the Wise." Both scriptures affirm that God's holiness inspires reverence, worship, and a commitment to live righteous lives that honor Him.

2. Moral Attributes of God

a) Loving

God's love is unconditional and universal.

Bible: "For God so loved the world that He gave His one and only Son." (John 3:16)

Qur'an: "Indeed, Allah loves those who rely upon Him." (Surah Aal 'Imran 3:159)

b) Merciful

God forgives sins and shows compassion to those who repent.

Bible: "The Lord is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in love." (Psalm 103:8)

Qur'an: "And My Mercy encompasses all things." (Surah Al-A'raf 7:156)

c) Just

God is fair and righteous, rewarding good and punishing evil.

Bible: "For the Lord is righteous, He loves justice." (Psalm 11:7)

Qur'an: "Indeed, Allah does not do injustice, [even] as much as an atom's weight." (Surah An-Nisa 4:40)

Understanding the attributes of God helps learners to apply their faith in practical ways. They can trust God's power when facing challenges such as school exams, family struggles, or personal difficulties, knowing that He is omnipotent and able to help them succeed. They can pray with confidence, believing that God is omniscient and hears every prayer, even the silent ones in their hearts. Recognizing God's holiness encourages them to live pure lives by avoiding sin, bad habits, and negative influences, while striving to be honest and disciplined. Finally, by reflecting God's love, mercy, and justice, learners can treat classmates, neighbors, and the wider community with kindness, forgiveness, and fairness.

This not only strengthens their personal faith but also promotes peace, unity, and moral responsibility in Rwanda's society.

1.1.3 Importance of the attributes of God

Understanding God's attributes like His love, justice, power, and immutability—is very important for believers because:

It builds trust in God.

It gives comfort during hard times.

It deepens worship.

It guides daily living.

It helps believers know who they worship.

It inspires them to reflect God's character (love, mercy, truth) in their own lives.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 1.1

1. Explain these attributes of God: Omnipresence, Omniscience, Holiness, and oneness?
2. Choose the correct attribute of God (Holiness, oneness, auto-sufficiency, All-knowing)
 - a) God does not need to learn ----
 - b) God is indivisible -----
 - c) Without other beings God can survive -----
 - d) Only God possesses a pure morality -----
3. Choose one attribute of God and explain why learning it makes you a better person?
4. What do the Bible and Qur'an teach about knowledge, power of God, mercy, and God's love?

1.2. Understanding the attributes of God



Learning activity 1.2

After looking at the image, answer these questions:



1. Describe the whole image.
2. Explain where the elements in the image come from.
3. Do the elements in the image depend on one another?
4. Who created and arranged the system shown in the image?
5. From the image, what do you understand about God?

Understanding God's attributes is important for believers because it guides their faith, worship, and daily life. God is all-powerful, all-knowing, present everywhere, holy, loving, merciful, and just. These qualities help believers trust God and obey His will.

For Christians, knowing that God is loving and merciful encourages forgiveness, compassion, prayer, and service to others, following Jesus' teachings. For Muslims, believing in Allah's power, justice, and mercy inspires obedience to His commands, respect for His laws, and trust in Him in all situations. Both religions teach that God's holiness calls people to live good and righteous lives.

In Rwanda understanding God's attributes promotes unity, respect, and peace. It also helps young people face challenges like exams, poverty, or family problems with hope, courage, and moral responsibility.

a) The table helps us to know, understand, and explain God's attributes

Attribute	Meaning
God is One (Unique)	God has no partner or equal. He is incomparable with any other being (Surah AlIkhlās 112:1; Deuteronomy 6:4).
God is Holy	God never makes mistakes and never changes. He is pure, righteous, and incorruptible (Isaiah 6:15; Surah AlHashr 59).
God is Selfexistent	God has no source and does not depend on any creature (John 5:26; Revelation 4:11).
God is Immutable	God never changes. His Word remains the same (Malachi 3:6; Numbers 23:19).
God is Most Merciful	God is full of love, kindness, patience, forgiveness, and compassion (John 3:16; Qur'an 1:12).
God is Just	God is always fair (Psalm 89:14).

God is All-Powerful (Omnipotent)	Nothing is impossible for God. He has unlimited power (Jeremiah 32:17; Qur'an 2:255).
God is AllHearing	God hears every prayer and every word (Surah AlMujadila 58:1; John 10:27).
God is All-Seeing	God sees everything, both public and private.
God is AllKnowing (Omniscient)	God knows everything, visible and invisible (Hebrews 4:13; Surah Taha 20:7).
God has an Infinite Nature	God is eternal, immortal, and without end. He is Alpha and Omega (Revelation 1:8).



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 1.2

1. How does believing in God as All-knowing guide a student to act honestly?
2. How does knowing that God is everywhere help young people avoid bad behavior?
3. How does understanding the holiness of God influence a young person's behavior?
4. How does believing in the Oneness of God promote unity and peace?

1.3 Living according to God's Attributes



Learning activity 1.3



1. What are the images about?
2. What are Muslims doing on the image?
3. Discuss the statement: True belief means not only knowing about God's attributes, it is also to reflect them into our actions.

Living according to God's attributes inspiration means making every effort to reflect God's goodness in our daily actions. Understanding them is essential for genuine faith. They shape our worship, prayer, and daily life. They also protect us from false views, deepen our trust, and helping us to live with hope, confident in His love and faithfulness despite life's challenges. It moves faith from ordinary emotion to a knowledge-based relationships and it allows a genuine connection, obedience, and growth in character to become more like God.

Believers themselves benefit from the attributes of God. To live them improve from hopeless state to hopeful one, positive thought, will, freedom, love and friendship. Let us briefly assess the importance of some attributes of God for believers:

- a) **Omnipotence of God:** we discover our powerless and then we find refuge in God and we entrust our lives to God. We know that nothing is impossible to God and all permission come from God (Sovereignty of God)
- b) **Omniscience of God:** we cannot hide anything from God because he knows everything. We know that the true knowledge is to know and to respect God through His visible creatures (Job 28:28)
- c) **Omnipresence of God:** as we are always cared by God, we must also protect and care others.
- d) **Holiness of God:** it helps us to strive for holiness and to live communion with God by faith, hope, Works of love, and by ethical moral principles (Exodus20: 1-17)
- e) **Self-existence:** we discover that we depend on God who is independent and who is Auto-sufficient. We are called to live interdependence in our daily lives
- f) **Immutability:** we are called to be honest, trustworthy, loyal, faithful to the promises
- g) **Mercifulness:** the graces of God push and urge us to be kind, helpful, merciful to others (Luke 6:36)
- h) **Infinitude of God:** we discover our finitude and we entrust our life to Immortal God

In Rwanda, people often express their faith in God through names, culture, and daily life. The attributes of God remind us how to live well in our communities. Since God is **Unique and Perfect**, we should worship Him alone and strive to live righteously by following moral values such as ubunyamugayo (integrity). Because He is **Merciful and Forgiving**, we are encouraged to be kind, forgive our classmates, and help those in need, just as Rwandans value ubumuntu (humanity). God is **Just and All-Knowing**, so we must act fairly, avoid cheating in school, and behave well even when no one is watching.

His Power and Wisdom inspire us to rely on Him in prayer and make peaceful decisions, which supports Rwanda's culture of unity and reconciliation. Finally, since God is Patient and Faithful, we too should remain patient in challenges like exams or family struggles, and keep promises to others. These attributes guide Rwandan learners to grow in faith, discipline, and community spirit.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 1.3

1. What do these attributes of God motivate you to do in your social life?
 - a) God is love
 - b) Holiness of God
 - c) Mercifulness of God
 - d) God is All-Knowing
2. Discuss the relationship between Faith and works
3. Give one Qur'anic and one Biblical verse about God's love.
4. According to your financial capacity, perform a kind deed to poor/and sick people



END OF UNIT ASSESSMENT 3

PART A: KNOWLEDGE AND UNDERSTANDING

1. Define the attributes of God
2. Using a table, categorize the following attributes of God: love, holiness, mercifulness, auto-sufficiency, forgiveness, the supremacy, All-Knowing, tolerance, kindness, immortality, endless, power, infallible, wisdom, immutable, knowledge, truth, omnipresence, sovereignty, compassion
3. After you read each of the declarations below, respond by True or False in religious context
 - a) I have knowledge and wisdom so, I am omnipresent
 - b) I occupy the first position in my class, then I am omniscient
 - c) Kanyarwanda has children and grandchildren: he is then immortal
 - d) God took initiative to send Jesus and Muhammad PBUH for the people's benefit: it means God is Merciful
 - e) God possesses the pure immortality

PART B: SKILLS

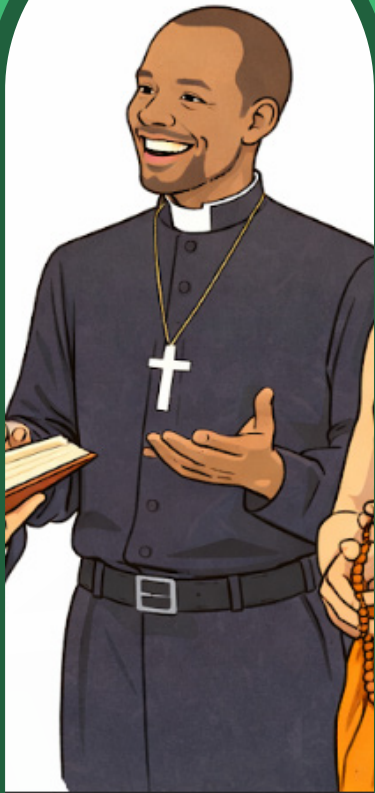
4. Match the attribute of God in Column A with the correct meaning in Column B.

Column A	Column B
a) Most Merciful	1. God knows everything
b) Just	2. God is full of kindness and compassion
c) All-Knowing	3. God is always fair and does no wrong

5. Is there any link between faith and Works? Served by the Quran and the Bible, justify your position
6. Discuss and contrast the following statement: the football team A won over team B because God was on side of team A
7. The sin will be called sin when it will be committed in public and known by many people
8. Prove how the attributes of God are spiritually, psychologically, religiously and morally important

PART C: ATTITUDES & VALUES

9. God is Love. How is this attribute helping to live well with others at school, at home as well as?
10. God is trustworthy, how can this attribute help you to grow socially and economically



UNIT II:

RELIGIOUS BELIEFS AND UNITY IN DIVERSITY

Key unit competence

The learner should be able to respect the diversity in religious doctrines consciously and live in harmony with other religious members.

Learning outcomes

By the end of the unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Define religion and belief systems, and explain their role in human life
- Identify similarities and differences between Islam and Christianity.
- Explain the meaning and importance of unity in diversity.
- Describe the importance of cooperation between different faith groups.
- Identify common causes of religious conflict and disunity and suggest ways to promote interfaith harmony.

Skills

- Identify key beliefs of major world religions.
- Show how interfaith skills promote unity and peace.
- Identify the way to promote unity among people of different religions and cultures
- Participate in simulated interfaith activities and discussions.
- Suggest practical ways to resolve religious misunderstandings.

Attitude and values

- Appreciate the role of religion in guiding moral behaviour and daily life.
- Respect all people and value shared religious principles.

INTRODUCTION

Religious beliefs are the ideas and teachings that people follow about God, life, and how to live in a good way. In Rwanda, as in many countries, people belong to different religions such as Christianity, Islam, and traditional beliefs. These beliefs may have different prayers, worship styles, and practices, but they often teach similar values like love, peace, honesty, and respect.

Unity in diversity means living together in harmony even when we are different. Rwanda is a country that values togetherness, and students should learn to respect all religions. Diversity should not divide us, but help us understand one another better. When we accept others' beliefs, we promote peace and friendship in schools and communities.

Religious unity does not mean everyone must believe the same thing. Instead, it means we cooperate, support each other, and avoid discrimination. By appreciating religious diversity, we build a stronger society where everyone feels included. As young people, senior two students have an important role in promoting tolerance, dialogue, and national unity.



Introductory activity

Answer these questions

1. What are religious beliefs?
2. Which different religions are found in Rwanda?
3. What does "unity in diversity" mean?
4. Why should students respect people with different religious beliefs?
5. How can religious diversity help build peace and friendship in society?

2.1. Meaning of religion and belief systems and the importance of religion in moral guidance



Learning activity 2.1

Observe the images and answer the following questions:



1. Which religion are you relating to each of the elements found on the above image?
2. What do you understand by religion?
3. How do religions shape believers' morality?

2.1.1. Meaning of Beliefs

Beliefs are convictions or strong feelings that something is true, even without absolute proof. They shape our worldview, identity, and actions.

Example: belief in God, belief that honesty is important, belief that the sun will rise tomorrow.

2.1.2. Meaning of Religion

The word religion comes from Latin religio (respect for the sacred) and religare (to bind). Religion is a bond between humans and God. It is a set of beliefs and practices shared by a group of people.

Examples of religions

- **Christianity:** Belief in one God and in the teachings, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.
- **Islam:** Belief in one God (Allah), six Articles of Faith, and five Pillars of Islam.
- **Judaism:** Belief in one God, teachings of the Torah.
- **Hinduism:** Beliefs and traditions include concepts such as Brahman, karma, reincarnation, dharma, and moksha; Hindu traditions are diverse in their understanding of the divine.

2.1.3. Importance of Religion in Moral Guidance

- Religion defines right and wrong.
- Encourages good conduct (love, justice, honesty).
- Discourages vices (lying, stealing, hatred).
- Provides moral laws.

a) **In Islamic hadith** we find seven grave sins known as **Al-Mawbiqat** that means **destroying sins** that are:

- Shirk (associating partners with Allah),
- Sorcery,
- Unjust killing,
- Consuming interest/ Riba (Usury),
- Consuming an orphan's wealth,
- Deserting in battle when Muslims are engaged in lawful defense
- Slandering chaste women/accusing a believing woman of adultery

These sins are considered extremely destructive as they undermine core Islamic principles of faith, life, family, and justice.

b) **In Christianity**, the forbidden sins and the duties are summarized into Decalogue known as Ten Commandments (**Exodus 20:1-17**):

1. You shall have no other gods before me.
2. You shall not make for yourself an idol and worship it.
3. You shall not misuse the name of the Lord your God.
4. Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy.
5. Honor your father and your mother.
6. You shall not murder.
7. You shall not commit adultery.
8. You shall not steal.
9. You shall not give false testimony against your neighbor.
10. You shall not covet your neighbor's house, wife, manservant and maidservant, ox or donkey, and anything that belongs to your neighbours.

To condemn vices, Christianity urges believers to uproot what are called the root causes of sins and vices like: jealousy, anger, pride, greediness, selfishness, laziness and sexual lust.

c) **In Judaism** there are severe prohibitions that one must die rather than committing them. According to the principle of **Ye'hareg y'al ya'avur** (be killed but do not transgress) these are: **murder, idolatry (worshiping other gods), and certain sexual misconducts** (like incest, adultery)

Other major sins are Chilul Hashem (blaspheming God's name) through public transgressions, especially by religious figures, and sins against others like slander, theft, and causing injury. Those sins require a sincere repentance (teshuvah)

Not only in monotheistic religions; the polytheistic and even atheistic religions have moral principles of preventing immoralities for example in Hinduism like in Christianity there are **big behaviors** called behaviours to be avoided: kama (Desire/Lust), krodha (Anger), lobha (Greed), mada (Ego), moha (Attachment), and matsarya (Jealousy) and alasya (laziness). To sum up religion is important because:

- It encourages honesty, kindness, respect, and justice.
- At the same time, it discourages stealing, lying, corruption, and hatred.
- Religion also promotes forgiveness, peace, and love among people.
- Through faith, people gain a sense of purpose and responsibility before God.
- In addition, religious teachings help control human desires and avoid evil.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.1

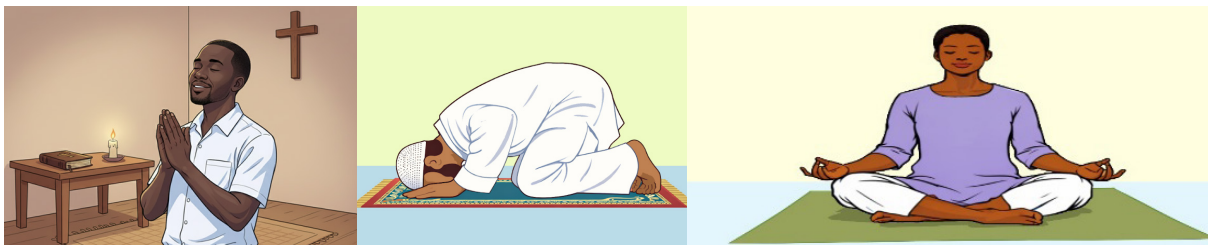
1. Define religion and belief system.
2. Mention two examples of world religions and their fundamental beliefs.
3. Discuss: No society without beliefs and religion.
4. Explain two examples of daily life moral behaviors from the beliefs and religions we belong to.

2.2. Major World Religions and their followers



Learning activity 2.2

Observe the images below carefully and answer the questions that follow:



1. Look at the elements in the image and tell the religions they represent
2. Mention other religions you know in the world
3. What are the followers of the mentioned religions called and what is the name of place of prayer for each religion

2.2.1. Categories of religions according to fundamental beliefs

Religion	Founder	Sacred Book	Place of Worship	Followers' Name
Christianity	Jesus Christ	Bible	Church	Christians
Islam	Prophet Muhammad (Peace be upon him)	Qur'an	Mosque	Muslims
Judaism	Abraham (Patriarch of the covenant with God)	Torah	Synagogue	Jews
Hinduism	No single founder	Vedas	Temple	Hindus
Buddhism	Siddhartha Gautama (Buddha)	Tripitaka	Pagoda/ Temple	Buddhists
Confucianism	Confucius	Analects	Temples/Halls	Confucianists
Traditional African Religion	Ancestors/ Indigenous people	Oral traditions	Shrines/Sacred places	African Traditionalists

2.2.2. Different fundamental religious beliefs in world

1. Fundamental beliefs in Judaism



Torah is a Holy Book for Jews

- All Jewish beliefs, practices and scholarship are primarily based on Torah known as the Five Books of Moses or Pentateuch: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy
- The Torah, Nevi'im (Prophets) and Ketuvim (other Writings) together form the Jewish/Hebrew Bible called Tanakh
- To be Jewish is to learn Torah: Knowledge is power, and to know God's ways is to connect to Him in the deepest way possible. That's why Jewish people invest hours, days and years into learning Torah and Talmud, plumbing their inexhaustible depths for more meaning and insight.
- Aside from the Tanakh, there is Talmud which refers to the teachings of Rabbis in their own words transmitted (tradition) from old teachers, going back in a direct transmission from Sinai. Obviously the Tanakh looks like the Old Testament but Jews don't use this term because it involves a 'New' Testament they do not believe.

- The key belief of Judaism is: "there exists only one eternal God who is the creator and the ruler of the universe and all that are in it. This is contained in the Biblical "Shema" (which means "Hear", "Obey"): "Hear O Israel the Lord is our God, the Lord is one..." (Deuteronomy 6:4-6).
- Shabbat: God's gift to the Jews (The Sabbath Day): On the Sabbath day Jews remember the story of creation from the Torah where God created the world in six days and rested on the seventh day. Known as Shabbat, the day is dedicated to prayer **services**, festive meals **with family and friends**, and **rest. On Shabbat we acknowledge that God created the world in six days and rested on the seventh.**
- Jews believe that Messiah has not come yet. He will come to earth to bring a time of perfect peace and prosperity. Ever since God created the world, we have been building up toward the climax, a time of peace and Godly awareness.

Sects in Judaism

They are Jewish religious subgroups with different aspects of

- d) **Pharisees:** The word "Pharisee" etymologically means "separated one, separatist". Pharisees started to appear between 150-140 BCE. They are known **characterized by strict observance of the traditional and written law, and commonly held to have pretensions to superior sanctity**. They believed in the resurrection of the dead, in angels and future rewards and punishments (Acts 23:8). Note that certain Pharisees like Nicodemus supported Jesus.
- e) **Sadducees:** Sadducees are regarded by some as the descendants of Zadok, Solomon's priest (2 Samuel 8:17). They collaborated with the Romans (the oppressive rulers). They regarded the Torah as binding, and rejected **the idea of two categories of good and evil spirits (Acts 23:8)**. They rejected also the belief in the resurrection of the body (**Luke 20:27-33**), rewards and punishments in Hades (hell); etc.
- f) **Scribes:** A class of professional scholars learned in the law, i.e. people who are learned in the Scriptures (Mark 2:4). They are also called **"the teachers of the law"** (Acts 5:34).
- g) **Zealots:** The zealots' **ideology** is found in Jewish concept of "zeal," that means a **total** commitment to God's will and law. They worshipped the traditional Judaic god and they resisted Romans considered for them as occupiers or conquerors.

2. Fundamental beliefs in Christianity



Christianity is a monotheistic religion centered on the personage of Jesus of Nazareth, or Jesus Christ. Christianity emerged from the ministry, death, resurrection, and followers of Jesus in the first century CE; Pentecost is traditionally regarded as an important early event in the Church's history (Acts 2:1-13) and it was its beginning considered as Jewish sect to be stopped (Saul of Tarsus). Christianity is the teachings of Jesus, who was himself Jewish. The believers in Christ are called Christians that mean Disciples of Christ. **Fundamental beliefs:** believe in the trinity, the divine and human natures of Jesus, His Death and Resurrection, both Old and New Testament, the Holy Spirit, the Baptism, last judgment and eternal life in Heaven.

3. The fundamental beliefs in Islam

Islam is a strict monotheistic religion began with the revelations received by the Prophet Muhammad, PBUH (Peace be upon him) the Hijrah to Medina occurred in 622 CE. This religion is founded on five pillars:

Pillar	Arabic	Meaning	Simple Explanation
1. Shahadah	شهادة	Declaration of Faith	Saying "La ilaha illa Allah, Muhammadur Rasul Allah" meaning "There is no other God who deserves to be worshiped in truth except Allah., and Muhammad is His messenger."
2. Salah	صلاة	Prayer	Muslims pray five times a day to remember and thank Allah.
3. Zakah	زكاة	Giving Alms	Muslims give part of their wealth to help the poor and purify their income.
4. Sawm	صوم	Fasting	Muslims fast during Ramadan to learn self-control and sympathy for the needy.
5. Hajj	حج	Pilgrimage	Every Muslim who is able must go to Makkah once in their life.

In 610 CE, he began receiving revelations that form the Qur'an. This book consists of 114 chapters called surahs, divided into ayat (verses). The Quran was received by Muhamad but written by his disciples. Aside Quran there is **Hadith** that is recorded says of the prophet Muhammad and they became source of **Sharia** that is Islamic laws

Sunnah refers to the Prophet Muhammad's practices, teachings, and example, practices which are model for all Muslims transmitted from his time up today. Muhammad faced a serious persecution from polytheistic people of Mecca and decided **Hijrah** also **Hegira** which means the journey the Islamic prophet Muhammad and his followers took from Mecca (Makkah) to Medina (Madinah) where he founded the first Muslims community in 22AC

The six pillars of fundamental beliefs in Islam are known as Articles of Faith: belief in one God (Allah), in angels, in prophets, in holy books, in the Day of Judgment, and in pre-ordainment. These beliefs are considered essential for Muslims and shape their worldview and practices.

Muslims believe also in **Night of decree in Islam**: Laylatul Qadr, the Night of Decree or Night of Power, is one of the most sacred nights in the Islamic calendar. It takes place in the last ten days of Ramadan and was the night in which the Qur'an was revealed to the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). It is the Night of answers to questions and night in which lucky and unlucky for next year are prefixed. **Haram** are all unlawful behaviors in Islam while **Halaal** means all lawful behaviors in Islam

4. Hinduism beliefs

Hinduism is among the world's oldest living religious traditions. The religion has no founder. It is a synthesis of many different Indian religious traditions. It is non-theistic and non-Christian religion but polytheistic religion. Examples of major Hindu deities: **Brahma** the creator, **Vishnu** the preserver and **Shiva** the destroyer. The religious sacred texts of Hinduism are **Vedas**.

Fundamental beliefs in Hinduism:

The main beliefs in Hinduism include concepts of Brahman, Atman (soul), karma, reincarnation (Soul of dead returns in other living) and moksha. Essentially, Hindus believe in a universal **soul (Brahman as supreme Spirit)** and an individual soul (**Atman**) that is eternal. **Actions** in this life are understood in relation to **karma**(law of cause and effect) that determines the cycle of rebirth (**Samsara**) and the goal is to achieve liberation (**moksha**: be free from suffering in cycle of samsara). The highest state of perfection in Hinduism is called NIRVANA: state of enlightenment, spiritual achievement, pure knowledge, perfect rites. A major spiritual goal in many Hindu traditions is moksha, liberation from the cycle of rebirth.

In summary there 7 fundamental beliefs in Hinduism which are guided by principles like:

- **Brahman** : Supreme spirit/ ultimate reality
- **Atman**: the inner self/the Soul which is immortal
- **Dharma**: righteousness/ duties (cosmic order)
- **Karma**: action and its consequences/law of action or law of cause and effects
- **Samsara**: Cycle of rebirth(death and rebirth) and reincarnation
- **Moksha**: Liberation from suffering in cycle of rebirth
- **Yoga**: path to spiritual realization/meditation

The realization of these truths forms a framework for life, ethics, and spiritual goals. These concepts guide Hindus towards understanding their inner self (Atman) and its connection to the divine (Brahman).

5. Fundamental beliefs in Buddhism

Buddhism is a non-Christian religious and philosophical tradition. A religious tradition founded by Gautama Buddha. The term Buddha means "**awakened one**" or "**enlightened one**". This religion continued to grow and develop in East Asia, having a profound impact on the cultural landscape of the entire region.

Buddhist sacred book is **Tripitaka** with message: **rules for monastic life discipline, accounts on the Buddha's life, various philosophical treatises.**

Buddhists strive for overcoming desire and **ending suffering** (The purpose of life in Buddhism) to reach **full liberation** called nirvana through understanding and practicing the **Four Noble Truths: truth of suffering, of cause of suffering, of end of suffering and truth of the path that leads to the end of suffering** and the **Eightfold Path**: right understanding, right intent/thoughts, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right concentration.

Key tenets (Laws of beliefs) include: **impermanence, karma** as law of cause and effect or law of action, the **rebirth** and **dharma** "cosmic law": live harmony with all livings (values, virtues).

6. Confucianism beliefs

a) Meaning of Confucianism

Confucianism is generally described as a philosophical and ethical tradition rather than simply an atheistic religion centered on Self-cultivation, the creation of a harmonious society through virtue and morality. Confucianism is not a religion in a strict sense. It is a **philosophy** that draws on the **folk religion** (based on cultures) of China. Confucianism as a school of thought was founded by the Chinese philosopher Kong better known as Master Kong later named Confucius.

It quickly became one of the most influential of the "Hundred Schools of Thought" and became the foundation of the later imperial government of China. Confucianism is still concentrated in China, but its teachings are widespread throughout East Asia.

b) Fundamental beliefs in Confucianism:

Confucianism's beliefs center **on social harmony, moral self-cultivation or ethical behavior, the importance of family and community and education as path to virtues.**

Key tenets/laws include **filial piety** (respect for elders/ancestors or hierarchy), **the concept of ren** (benevolence and humaneness), and **the emphasis on rituals** and **social order**. These beliefs guide personal conduct, social interactions, and governance, leading to a harmonious and well-ordered society.

The 5 relationships that make a harmonious society (social order) via mutual duties should be hierarchical: **ruler and subject, father and son, husband and wife, elder and younger brother, and friend and friend**. These relationships are hierarchical, with **superiors** (ruler, father, husband, elder brother) expected to be benevolent and **the inferiors** (subjects, son, wife, younger brother) to be loyal and respectful. It will foster a harmonious society modeled on the family unity, with friendship being from the only equal relationship.

Confucianism centers on virtues like

Ren (benevolence),
Zhi (wisdom),

Yi (righteousness),
Xin (trustworthiness),

Li (propriety/ritual),
Xiao (filial piety)

7. Traditional beliefs

a) Definition

They are called Traditional religions/beliefs because they do not typically refer to **modern** but **to indigenous/native system of beliefs, practices, and cultural customs** that have been established over a long period within a specific community or society.

b) Basic beliefs of traditional beliefs

- beliefs in spirits
- belief in higher and lower gods,
- belief in a supreme being in some traditions,
- belief in life after death,
- the veneration of the dead, worship of protectors, deities, worship of nature, ancestor worship and
- Some traditional African religions also have elements of *totemism* (humans have relationship with spiritual living like plant, animals), *shamanism* (believe that shamans can heal sick people by communicating with the spirit world) and *veneration of relics*.
- Ancestors are regarded as intermediaries between humans and the Supreme Being in some traditions.
- Use of magic and traditional African medicine.
- Most of them can be **described as animistic** (believing that plants and inanimate objects have a living soul and there is a Supernatural power that animates/organize the universe material) with various polytheistic and as **pantheistic** aspects (believe that what is divine is right here on earth: the earth, universe, nature are divine to be treated as sacred)
- The famous **traditional beliefs in Rwanda** include *Veneration of ancestors (Guterekera: appeasing or pacifying ancestors' anger)*, *Divination (Ubupfumu no Kuraguza: aims at knowing the cause and solution to misfortune)* and *The cult of initiation to Lyangombe (Kubandwa: to live a future better life)*

The table below shows different religions their founders, sacred book, places of worship and followers.

Religion	Founder	Sacred Book	Place of Worship	Followers' name
Christianity	Jesus Christ	Bible	Church	Christians
Islam	Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him)	Qur'an	Mosque	Muslims
Judaism	Abraham , the first Patriarch who contracted with God the covenant of monotheism when he left homeland to Canaan (1800BC)	Torah	Synagogue	Jews

Hinduism	No single founder	Vedas	Temple	Hindus
Buddhism	Siddhartha Gautama (Buddha)	Tripitaka	Pagoda/ Temple	Buddhists
Confucianism	Confucius	Analects	Temples/ Halls	Confucianists
Traditional African Religion	Ancestors /indigenous people (no single founder)	Oral traditions	Shrines/ Sacred places	African Traditionalists

Despite the particular beliefs of each religion; we **find the common values** that help believers to maintain social unity at large. The table below highlights some examples:

Value	What religions teach	Meaning
Tolerance	"There is no coercion in religion" (Qur'an 2:256)	Respect others' beliefs.
	Love your neighbor as yourself" (Mark 12:31)	Accept differences.
	Many paths lead to God	Respect for diverse beliefs.
Peace and Unity	Practice non-violence and mindfulness (Buddhism)	Live in harmony with others.
	Community rituals	Promote unity in society
	Ummah (community) and helping neighbors (Islam)	Foster community and togetherness
Respect for Diversity	Recognition of multiple paths to the divine (Hinduism)	Value differences in beliefs
	Respect for different roles in society and family (Confucianism)	Appreciate social and cultural diversity
	Acceptance of others (Christianity)	Accept different ways of life
Brotherhood and Coexistence	Blessed are the peacemakers" (Matthew 5:9, Christianity)	Promote harmony and cooperation.
	Helping neighbors and fostering community ties (Islam)	Support and care for others
	Laws and teachings encourage care for others (Judaism)	Build strong communities



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.2

Multiple Choice Questions

- The particular sacred book for Islam is:
 - The Bible
 - The Quran
 - The Torah
 - The Vedas
- Which value is taught by all major religions to promote harmony and cooperation?
 - Competition
 - Brotherhood and coexistence
 - Individualism
 - Material wealth

3. Match each religion with its correct founder and place of worship.

Religion	Founder / Place of Worship
1. Christianity	a) Temple
2. Islam	b) Church, Jesus
3. Hinduism	c) Temple, Gautama Buddha
4. Buddhism	d) Mosque, Prophet Muhammad

4. Why is it important to respect people of other religions?

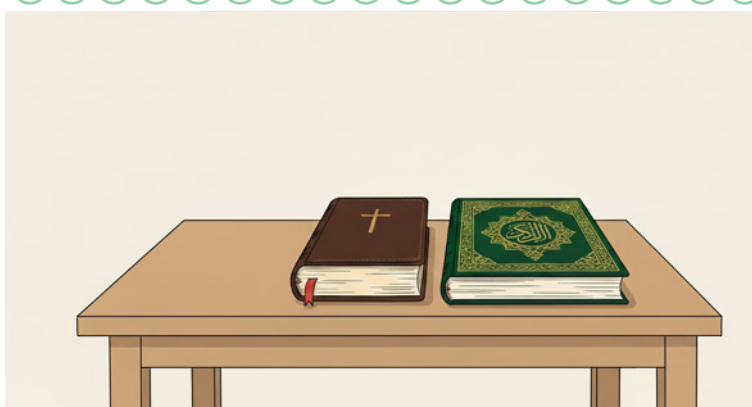
5. With two common values, explain how they can help us live peacefully in society.

2.3. Core Beliefs in Islam and Christianity



Learning activity 2.3

Observe the image and answer the questions that follow:



1. What are the main sacred texts in Islam and Christianity, and how do they guide the daily lives of believers?
2. Compare the practices of prayer in Islam and Christianity. In what ways are they similar, and how are they different?

Islam and Christianity are two of the world's largest religions, shaping the lives of billions of people across different cultures and continents. Both faiths are rooted in monotheism, emphasizing belief in one God, moral responsibility, and the importance of worship. While they share many values such as love, compassion, and justice, they also differ in their understanding of God, scripture, and the role of key figures like Jesus and Muhammad.

Core Beliefs in Christianity	Core beliefs in Islam
	
• Monotheism: Belief in one God, revealed in three persons (Trinity: Father, Son, Holy Spirit). • Jesus Christ: Belief that Jesus is the Son of God, fully human and fully divine. • Salvation: Through faith in Jesus' death and resurrection, believers receive forgiveness and eternal life. • Scripture: The Bible (Old and New Testament) is the inspired word of God. • Sacraments: Practices such as Baptism and Holy Communion are central to Christian life. • Love and Forgiveness: Command to love God and neighbor (Matthew 22:37–39). • Final Judgment: Belief in eternal life in heaven or separation from God after death	• Monotheism (Tawhid): Belief in one God (Allah), who is all-powerful and merciful. • Prophethood: Muhammad (PBUH) is the final prophet; Muslims also honor earlier prophets like Moses and Jesus. • Scripture: The Qur'an is the word of God revealed to Muhammad; Hadith records his sayings and actions. • Five Pillars of Islam: 1. Shahadah – Declaration of faith. 2. Salah – Prayer five times daily. 3. Zakah – Giving to the poor. 4. Sawm – Fasting during Ramadan. 5. Hajj – Pilgrimage to Mecca. • Articles of Faith: Belief in Allah, angels, prophets, holy books, Day of Judgment, and divine destiny. • Moral Conduct: Emphasis on honesty, justice, charity, and compassion. • Afterlife: Belief in heaven (Jannah) and hell (Jahannam), with accountability on the Day of Judgment.

In summary, the core beliefs of Islam and Christianity highlight both unity and diversity in humanity's search for God. Their similarities—such as devotion to one God, moral guidance, and hope in eternal life—promote respect and dialogue between followers. At the same time, their differences remind us of the richness of religious traditions

and the need for tolerance. By appreciating these beliefs, people can foster peace, unity, and coexistence in society.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.3

1. After reading each declaration, respond by True or False
 - a) Muhammad was the recipient of the Qur'anic revelation, not its author
 - b) All Christians do not share the same teachings about Mary; the death and resurrection of Jesus are central to Christianity
 - c) Muhammad PBUH received the Quranic message from Allah
 - d) The Five Pillars are the practices of Islam; the Articles of Faith are six
2. Identify the fundamental pillars of Islamic faith
3. Talk about the composition of the Trinity in Christianity
4. In Christianity, the Church is apostolic, explain

2.4. Islam and Christianity: "similarities and differences"



Learning activity 2.4

In the Nyamirambo sector, a Muslim shopkeeper named Ahmad and his Christian neighbor, Peter, lived side by side. One day, heavy rain destroyed the small house of an old widow, Chantal. When they heard the news, Ahmad mobilized Muslims at the mosque to collect Sadaqah, while Peter informed his church group, who gathered food and blankets. Later that day, both groups met at Chantal's home and worked together to repair her house. Ahmad thanked Allah and quoted Prophet Muhammad PBUH about helping others, and Peter thanks God and quoted Jesus about loving your neighbor as you love yourself. They agreed to continue supporting their community together.



1. Mention one similarity between Islam and Christianity shown in the story.
2. Mention one difference between Islam and Christianity shown in the story.
3. How did both religions promote peace and cooperation in the community?

Islam and Christianity are two of the world's largest monotheistic religions, each with billions of followers across the globe. Both faiths share common values such as love, compassion, and belief in one God, yet they differ in their understanding of God, scripture, and religious practices. Exploring these similarities and differences helps promote respect, unity, and peaceful coexistence among diverse communities.

Similarities

- **Monotheism:** Both believe in one supreme God.
- **Moral Values:** Emphasize honesty, kindness, forgiveness, and justice.
- **Sacred Texts:** Both have holy books (the Bible for Christians, the Qur'an for Muslims).
- **Prayer and Worship:** Regular prayer and devotion are central.
- **Prophets:** Both honor prophets like Abraham and Moses.
- **Afterlife:** Belief in heaven and hell, and accountability after death.
- **Charity:** Helping the poor is a shared religious duty.

Differences

Aspect	Christianity	Islam
View of God	Trinity: Father, Son, Holy Spirit	Tawhid: Absolute oneness of Allah
Jesus Christ	Son of God, divine and savior	Prophet, not divine
Scripture	Bible (Old and New Testament)	Qur'an and Hadith
Salvation	Through faith in Jesus	Through faith, good deeds, and obedience
Religious Practices	Baptism, Holy Communion, Sunday worship	Five Pillars of Islam, Friday prayers
Clergy	Priests, pastors	Imams, scholars
Founding	Around 33 AD (Pentecost)	622 AD (Hijrah to Medina)

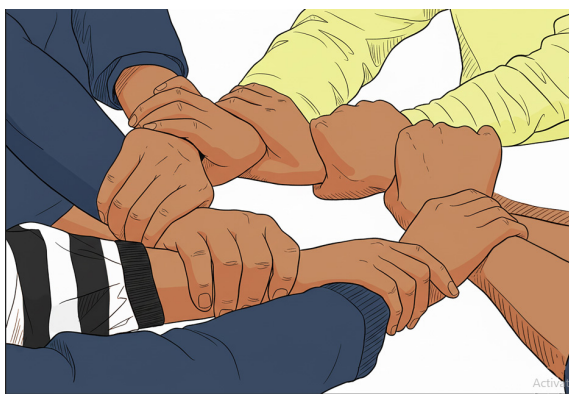
While Islam and Christianity differ in theology and rituals, they share many values that promote peace, compassion, and social harmony. Understanding both religions helps build respect and unity among people of different faiths. In a diverse society like Rwanda, learning about these similarities and differences encourages tolerance and peaceful coexistence.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.4

1. What are two similarities between Islam and Christianity?
2. What is one main difference between Islam and Christianity?
3. Why is it important for Christians and Muslims to live in peace and respect each other?

2.5. The Concept of Unity in diversity



By our unity, we reach more



Learning activity 2.5

1. Observe the images above and detect what they symbolize
2. What do you understand by the terms: unity and Diversity?
3. Prove the necessity of inclusive unity in society

Meaning of terms

- a) Unity:** means living together in harmony and peace, sharing common goals and respecting one another.
- b) Diversity:** means differences among people in religion, race, language, culture, gender, and opinions. It means being different but still living together peacefully and working toward the common good.
- c) Unity in diversity**

The concepts of unity in diversity refers to the principle of harmony and strength found in a group despite differences in culture, religion, language, or background, emphasizing that diversity enriches rather than divides by fostering mutual respect, understanding, and coexistence for a stronger, more vibrant society. Unity in diversity reflects a **pluralistic character** that means the active and *positive process* of those different groups coexisting, engaging, and working together with mutual respect, valuing differences rather than just tolerating them.

The basic principles of unity in diversity are:

- seeing differences as strengths,
- promoting inclusion over exclusion,
- valuing shared humanity,
- building bridges through cooperation and empathy,
- not forcing uniformity.

Benefits of Unity in Diversity and Consequences of Disunity

1. Benefits of unity

- Promotes peace and cooperation.
- Encourages respect and love.
- Leads to socio-economic development.
- Reduces discrimination and conflict.
- Develops a spirit of solidarity and reducing extreme selfishness

2. Consequences of disunity

- Conflicts, hatred, war, and discrimination.
- Lack of development and the emergence of mistrust among people.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.5

1. How can students promote unity in a school where people come from different religious backgrounds?
2. What are the dangers of ignoring diversity and promoting division?
3. Give 2 examples from daily life that show unity among people who are different in culture or belief.

2.6. Interfaith relationships and cooperation



Learning activity 2.6

1. Looking at the way people in the image are dressed, are those people from the same religion?
2. Detect the possible reasons they are looking like panelists?

Meaning of Interfaith Relationship and Cooperation



Interfaith refers to dialogue involving people of different religions, focusing on dialogue, understanding, cooperation, and shared values like compassion and peace, rather than unifying beliefs, for example, the interaction between Muslims and Christians, Jews and Hindus, etc.

Cooperation means working together for a common good, such as peace, charity, and development.

Reasons for Interfaith Cooperation

The interfaith dialogue and cooperation are crucial for fostering and promoting inner peace and security.

- challenge outdated and traditional perceptions.
- building stronger and cohesive communities through
- mutual understanding, respect, and cooperation between different faiths,
- Islam and Christianity encourage believers to address global challenges such as injustice, environmental hazards, and calamities together.
- Elevating personal spiritual growth.
- It moves beyond stereotypes or castes to building empathy and solving common problems like poverty, ignorance, diseases, and creating more inclusive societies where religious diversity is seen as a strength, not a division, through open, respectful conversation and joint action.

Ways to promote interfaith cooperation

- Respect other religions' beliefs and practices
- Engage in dialogue and joint projects
- Avoid hate speech and discrimination
- Promote peace clubs in schools
- Teach moral and civic values



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.6

1. What is interfaith cooperation?
2. How can religion promote peace in society?

3. Give two benefits of interfaith relationships.
4. What can students do to promote interfaith harmony in their school?

2.7. Impact of religious sects in the society



He performs a healing prayer and he will finally be paid in terms of thanksgiving



Learning activity 2.7

Discuss in groups:

1. Define the term sect. What are the religious sects/groups works in your sector?
2. Think of your community: what positive role do religious sects play there?
3. What problems have you seen or heard about sectarian divisions?
4. Suggest one way schools can teach learners to respect different religious sects.

Understanding religious sects

- Formerly, "**sect**" came from Latin **secta**, meaning "a way, road, or following," derived from *sequi* («to follow»), referring to a school of thought or way of life. In this sense, Christianity, Islam, and Judaism are considered monotheistic sects.
- The meaning of sect changed due to confusion with another Latin **secta** from **secare**, "to cut." This context gave a new meaning to sect as **a group "cut off" or divided from a larger one**, especially in religion. In this context, Catholicism, Protestantism, Adventism, Anglican and their related subdivisions like the Orthodox Church and branches of Protestantism can be considered as Christian **sects**. Sunni and Shia are considered Islamic sects.

A religious sect is then defined as a smaller group that splits from a larger, established religion (denomination) due to disagreements over beliefs or practices, emphasizing dissimilar interpretations and acting as a "purer" or different path within the broader religion. These groups may form around **charismatic leaders**, hold strong views on societal norms, and see themselves as holding the true understanding, distinguishing themselves from the parent church.

Characteristics of contemporary sects

- Proclaim to be the only ones to teach the authentic truth
- Proclaim themselves to be especially charismatic and spiritually gifted
- Self-displayer of direct miracle performers and healing of different resistant diseases
- Claim to receive divine visions about other people's lives
- Some of them misuse the word of God by interpreting it in their own interest

The positive impacts of religious sects

- They promote moral values and good behavior
- They provide social support (charity, helping the needy)
- They strengthen unity and cooperation during community work
- They offer counseling and emotional support
- They promote peace and reconciliation
- They pick the abandoned people from a hopeless situation of isolation, and they increase their hope

The negative Impacts of religious sects

- They can cause conflicts due to doctrinal differences
- Spread division when one group believes it is superior
- Misinformation or extreme teachings may confuse youths
- Noise pollution from loud worship practices
- Wrong interpretation of the sacred books
- Some of them promote laziness and poverty by taking believers longtime at church
- Developing hatred due to religious extremism
- Sometimes discourage cooperation with other sects
- Praying in places with a high risk of losing life
- Some religious groups may be founded primarily for financial gain (scam, illegal pulling of people's economy, and human trafficking practices)
- Some religious sects urge believers not to eat some food, not to attend civic acts, and not to look for modern medical care; the governmental plans are challenged.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 2.7

1. Name any four Christian denominations or religious groups that work in Rwanda
2. Identify any three monotheistic religions that work in the world
3. Discuss and contrast: we must always spend our time to the church to pray for our spiritual growth
4. Assess the practices of a religious sect and identify any 4 practices that will would discourage you from joining it.



END OF UNIT ASSESSMENT 2

PART A: KNOWLEDGE AND UNDERSTANDING

1. List any of five major world religions.
2. Explain two similarities between Islam and Christianity.
3. Describe two differences between Islam and Christianity.
4. Using one among the given words, complete the following sentences contextually: **traditional beliefs, Islam, Hinduism, Christianity, social order, Torah, unity, reincarnation, Tanakh, to end suffering, Death on the cross**
 - a) The fundamental principle or belief in Confucianism is-----
 - b) Belief in ancestors' intercession is among the core beliefs of -----
 - c) The key fundamental belief in Judaism is-----while its sacred book is-----
 - d) We believe differently, but we should live in our differences
 - e) -----is among the tenets of Hinduism and Buddhism
 - f) Christians believe that Salvation was accomplished through Jesus'-----
 - g) The purpose of life in Buddhism is to end-----
 - h) The supreme Spirit as creator in -----is Brahman
 - i) ----- teaches the oneness of Allah
 - j) Many Christian denominations -----believe in divine and human nature in Jesus Christ

PART B: SKILLS

1. Discuss five causes of the multiplication of religious sects
2. In a table of two columns, make a parallelism of any four elements between the Quran and the Bible

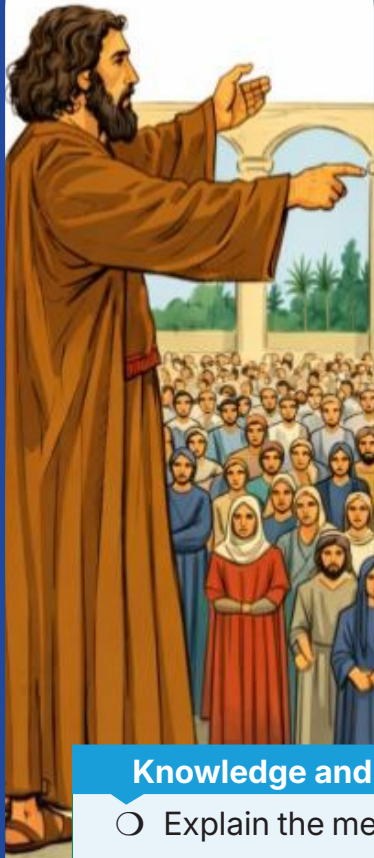
PART C: ATTITUDES & VALUES

Circle the letter that corresponds to the best answer:

1. Why is religion important in guiding human behaviour?
 - a) It helps people make moral decisions
 - b) It forces people to fear others
 - c) It teaches people to argue
 - d) It encourages discrimination
2. Which of the following actions best shows mutual respect between religions?
 - a) Insulting their beliefs
 - b) Listening and interacting respectfully
 - c) Avoiding them completely
 - d) Forcing them to accept your religion



3. To prevent the negative effects of religious movements, I must
- a) Totally submit myself to whatever sectarian leaders say to me
 - b) Imitate blindly
 - c) Hate all those who are not believers of our religion
 - d) Link faith and critical thinking



UNIT III:

EXPANSION OF CHRISTIANITY AND ISLAM

Key unit competence

The learner will be able to analyse the historical expansion of Christianity and Islam and appreciate their influence on moral, social, and cultural development in Rwanda and the world.

Learning outcomes

By the end of the unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Explain the meaning of religious expansion and identify the early stages of the spread of Islam and Christianity
- Describe how Christianity spread in different parts of the world.
- Define Da'wah and explain its importance in Islam.
- State reasons why religious expansion remains important today.

Skills

- Compare how both religions started spreading to different regions.
- Identify methods used by Christian missionaries to spread the gospel.
- Quote Qur'anic verses and hadiths emphasizing Da'wah.
- Suggest modern ways of spreading faith peacefully.

Attitude and values

- Appreciate that both religions aimed to spread faith and moral guidance, not hatred or division.
- Emulate the Prophet's patience, tolerance, and humility.
- Appreciate the courage and commitment of early Christians and Muslims in preserving their faith.

INTRODUCTION

In this unit, we will explore how Christianity and Islam began and spread across different regions of the world. We will learn about the origins of these religions, the early development of the Christian Church, and how Islam grew under the guidance of Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). The unit will also examine the methods of spreading these faiths, their influence beyond their original regions, and their continuing importance in promoting peace, unity, and moral values today.



Introductory activity

1. How did Islam and Christianity begin
2. How did Christianity and Islam expand until they reached Rwanda?
3. What challenges did the two religions face in their journey of expansion?

3.1. Introduction to the Expansion of Christianity and Islam



Learning activity 3.1

Using the library, internet, and other available resources, identify and explain the methods used by Christianity and Islam to spread around the world.

Meaning of expansion

Expansion means growth or an increase in different aspects.

Religious Expansion

Religious expansion means the spread of a religion to new people and places. It happens when more people start following the religion, when the religion has greater influence in society, and when it spreads to new regions. Religious expansion can be seen in three main ways:

- **Increase in the number of believers:** More people join and practice the religion.
- **Influence of the religion:** The religion affects people's daily life, culture, laws, and community practices.
- **Geographical area covered:** The religion spreads to new towns, cities, countries, or even continents.

Religious expansion is important because it shows how a religion grows and impacts the lives of many people in different places.

Introduction to the Expansion of Christianity

Christianity began in the **Middle East** and later spread to many parts of the world. Its expansion started with the work of **Jesus Christ and his Apostles**, who preached and taught Christian beliefs.

Christianity continued to spread through:

- The establishment of **Christian communities**
- **Missionary work and evangelism**
- **Trade, colonization, and immigration** in later periods

In many regions, Christianity adapted to **local cultures** (a process known as *enculturation or contextualization*). At the same time, it contributed to society by:

- Establishing **schools**
- Providing **health services**
- Teaching **moral values** such as love, honesty, and forgiveness

Main Phases of the Growth of Christianity

1. **Birth of Jesus Christ:** Christianity began with the birth of **Jesus Christ in Bethlehem** during the reign of **Herod the Great** and the Roman Emperor **Augustus Caesar**, who was associated with the census mentioned in Luke 2:1.
2. **Jesus as the Promised Messiah:** Christians believe that Jesus is the **King of Kings**, as foretold by the prophets (Isaiah 9:6). This belief caused fear among earthly rulers.
3. **Opposition from Herod:** King Herod the Great, fearing the loss of his throne, ordered the killing of all baby boys under two years old in Bethlehem in an attempt to kill Jesus (Matthew 2:16).
4. **Public Ministry of Jesus:** At about **30 years of age**, according to the Gospel chronology commonly inferred from Luke 3:23, Jesus began teaching in **Galilee**. He preached about the Kingdom of God and chose **twelve Apostles** to help spread His message.
5. **Death and Resurrection of Jesus:** After the **death and resurrection of Jesus**, His followers became more confident and committed to spreading His teachings.
6. **Pentecost and the Birth of the Church:** Christianity was publicly established on **Pentecost (33 AD)** when the **Holy Spirit** descended upon the Apostles, giving them courage to preach openly.
7. **Missionary Work of the Apostles:** The Apostles, especially **Paul**, traveled widely throughout the **Roman Empire**, preaching the Gospel and establishing Christian communities.
8. **Persecution of Christians:** Early Christians faced **persecution, divisions, false teachings (heresies), and opposition**. The first Christian martyr was **Stephen**, who was stoned to death in **36 AD**.
9. **Legalization of Christianity:** In **313 AD**, Emperor **Constantine** issued the **Edict of Milan**, which ended the empire-wide persecution of Christians and granted legal toleration and allowed freedom of worship.
10. **Spread through Translation of the Bible:** The translation of the **Bible into local languages** helped many people understand Christian teachings and accept Christianity.

Introduction to the Expansion of Islam

Islam began in **Mecca**, in the Middle East. **Prophet Muhammad (Peace Be Upon Him)** received revelations from **Allah (God)** through the Angel **Jibril (Gabriel)** starting in **610 AD**. He called people to worship **One God** and abandon idol worship. At first, many people rejected his message, mocked him, and persecuted his followers, eventually leading to the Hijrah to Medina in 622 CE.

Despite these difficulties, the Prophet remained patient, faithful, and committed to spreading the message of Islam.

Main Phases in the Expansion of Islam

- **Hijra (622 AD):** The migration of Prophet Muhammad and his followers from Mecca to Medina. This event marks the beginning of the **Islamic (Hijri) calendar**.
- **Medina** became the center of the first Muslim community and is the second holiest city in Islam.
- **Da'wah:** Muslims invited others to Islam through peaceful teaching, wisdom, and good conduct.
- **Trade:** Muslim traders spread Islam peacefully to **East Africa, West Africa, and Asia**.
- **Expansion under the Caliphs:** Leaders such as **Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman, and Ali** expanded Islamic rule to **Syria, Egypt, Persia, and North Africa**.
- **Intermarriage and cultural exchange** helped spread Islamic beliefs and values.
- **Education:** Qur'anic schools and Islamic scholars (**ulama**) taught people about Islamic faith and morals.

Conclusion

Christianity and Islam expanded through **teaching, trade, education, leadership, and cultural interaction**. Although they faced many challenges, both religions made important **social, moral, and cultural contributions**, such as promoting **peace, justice, education, and respect for human dignity**. Learning about their history helps students develop **tolerance, appreciation, and respect for all religions**.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 3.1

1. Choose one of the given words/group of words to complete each sentence below: **hijra, Milan edict, Medina, Herod the Great, Augustus Caesar, enculturation, da'wah, 622, Khadija, Pentecost, Stephen, Mecca**.
 - a) it refers to the first year of the Islamic lunar calendar, which corresponds to _____
 - b) Muhammad (PBUH) was born in _____
 - c) Jesus was born during the reign of _____ Roman emperor
 - d) The perpetrator of the infant murder that was targeting Jesus is -----
 - e) Officially, the Christian church was founded on the -----
 - f) Emperor Constantine announced the liberty of worship/religion by a declaration called _____
 - g) _____ is known as the migration of Muhammad from Mecca to Medina
 - h) The first Christian martyr, during the early period of Christianity, is _____
 - i) Muhammad (PBUH) is buried in _____
 - j) In Christianity, the adaptation or contextualization of the Gospel within indigenous culture is known as _____
 - k) She was a trader, and she became the wife of Muhammad PBUH. Her name is _____
2. Identify any five common values we get from both Islam and Christianity

3.2. Origins and growth of East Christianity



Learning activity 3.2

Instructions: Work in pairs. Read the questions carefully and give short, clear answers.

1. What comes to mind when you hear the word Christianity?
2. Is Christianity spread everywhere in the same way?

Early Christianity began in the 1st century CE after the teachings of Jesus Christ. His disciples spread the message of love, forgiveness, and salvation. Despite persecution, the faith grew quickly across the Roman Empire. Missionary work, strong community life, and eventual recognition made Christianity a major world religion.

Early Christianity spread through the Roman Empire in part because roads, common languages, and urban networks facilitated travel and communication, common languages like Greek and Latin, and urban centers where people gathered. Missionary work by apostles such as Paul helped establish churches in places like Corinth, Ephesus, and Rome. Although Christians faced persecution from Roman authorities, their commitment and community life helped attract followers. They lived in close communities, sharing resources and caring for the poor, which impressed outsiders. By the 4th century CE, Christianity gained legal status under Emperor Constantine and eventually became the dominant religion of the Roman Empire.

Christianity began with Jesus Christ in the 1st century CE and was spread through the Roman Empire by apostles and missionaries. Although early Christians faced persecution, their courage and strong faith helped the religion grow. By the 4th century, Christianity had gained recognition and became a major world religion.

3.2.1. Origins of Early Christianity

The Beginning of Christianity in the 1st Century CE

Christianity began in the 1st century CE with the life, teachings, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ in Palestine. His disciples and apostles spread His message of love, forgiveness, and salvation, forming the first Christian communities.

Spread of Christianity through the Roman Empire

Christianity spread through the Roman Empire mainly through the work of apostles and missionaries, especially Paul, who traveled widely and established churches in cities such as Corinth, Ephesus, and Rome. The Roman Empire's good roads, common languages like Greek and Latin, and busy urban centers made it easier for the message to reach many people. Despite persecution, the faith grew stronger, and Christian communities impressed outsiders by sharing resources and caring for the poor.

Challenges Faced by Early Christians

Early Christians faced persecution from Roman authorities who saw their faith as a threat to traditional religion and politics. They were sometimes imprisoned, tortured, or killed. Despite this, their courage and strong faith attracted more followers.

3.2.2. Origins of Early Christianity in Africa

Africa was among the **earliest regions outside Palestine** to receive Christianity.

How Christianity Reached Africa

- **Egypt:** Christianity arrived in **Alexandria** around the 1st century through missionaries and traders.
- **Ethiopia:** By the 4th century, King **Ezana of Axum** converted to Christianity, making Ethiopia one of the first Christian kingdoms.
- **North Africa:** Christianity spread to **Carthage (Tunisia)** and other Roman provinces.
- **Key Figures:** Early African Christian leaders included **St. Mark (Alexandria)** and **Tertullian (Carthage)**.

Methods of Expansion

- **Missionary work:** Apostles and early Christians preached the Gospel.
- **Trade routes:** Merchants carried Christian ideas along the Nile and Red Sea.
- **Royal support:** Kings like Ezana promoted Christianity in their kingdoms.
- **Church building:** Early churches and monasteries were established in Egypt and Ethiopia.

Challenges Faced

- **Resistance from traditional religions** (ancestor worship, local gods).
- **Roman persecution:** Early Christians in North Africa were sometimes killed for their faith.
- **Islamic expansion** (7th century): Christianity declined in many parts of North Africa but survived strongly in Ethiopia and Egypt.

Importance of Early Christianity in Africa

- Africa became a **center of Christian thought** (Alexandria was famous for theology).
- Ethiopia and Egypt preserved **ancient Christian traditions** still practiced today.
- Christianity influenced **African culture, art, and education**.

3.2.3. Origins of Early Christianity in Rwanda

Christianity reached Rwanda much later than other parts of Africa.

Arrival of Christianity in Rwanda

- **First Missionaries:** Catholic missionaries from the **White Fathers (Missionaries of Africa)** arrived in Rwanda in **1900**.

- They were operated in a colonial context in which German and later Belgian authorities exercised political power.
- Protestant missionaries also came later in 1907, establishing their own churches.
- **Methods of Expansion**
- **Missionary work:** Preaching the Gospel and teaching the Bible.
- **Education:** Missionaries built schools to teach literacy and Christian values.
- **Health services:** Hospitals and clinics were established to care for the sick.
- **Support from colonial powers:** Christianity was favored by German and Belgian rulers, which helped it spread quickly.
- **Challenges Faced**
- **Resistance from traditional beliefs:** Rwandans practiced indigenous religion centered on **ancestor worship and rituals**.
- **Suspicion of foreign influence:** Some saw Christianity as tied to colonial control.
- **Competition with Islam:** Islam had already entered Rwanda through traders from the East African coast.
- **Impact of Christianity in Rwanda**
- **Education:** Literacy increased as schools taught reading and writing.
- **Health:** Hospitals improved medical care.
- **Culture and politics:** Christianity influenced leadership, laws, and social life.
- **Religious diversity:** Rwanda became home to both Catholic and Protestant communities.

3.2.4. Growth of Early Christianity

After Jesus' death, Christianity grew gradually from a small Jewish movement into a global religion, supported by strong leadership, missionary work, community support, and its inclusive message.

- 1. Spread through the Apostles.** The Apostles, especially Peter and John, preached in towns, synagogues, and homes, teaching love, forgiveness, and faith in God. Their leadership organized early Christian communities and guided new believers.
- 2. Missionary Work of Paul** helped spread Christianity beyond Jewish communities by traveling to Asia Minor, Greece, and Rome. He established churches and reached Gentiles, making Christianity a universal religion.
- 3. Formation of Early Church Communities** as Christianity expanded, church structures developed. Deacons cared for the poor, while bishops and priests led worship. Communities shared resources and supported one another, strengthening the faith.
- 4. Challenges and Perseverance** Early Christians faced persecution from Romans and misunderstandings about their beliefs. Despite these difficulties, their courage, unity, and strong faith helped Christianity continue to grow.
- 5. Factors That Helped Christianity Grow** Christianity spread widely due to strong leadership, missionary work, its welcoming message, supportive communities, and Roman roads that made travel and communication easier.

Conclusion: Over time, Christianity expanded from Judea into Europe, North Africa, the Middle East, and eventually Africa, becoming a major world religion.

3.2.5. Growth of Christianity in Africa

Christianity reached Africa very early, beginning in **Egypt** in the 1st century CE through missionaries and traders. By the 2nd–3rd centuries, Christianity spread to **Carthage (Tunisia)** and other Roman provinces. Great thinkers like **Tertullian** and **Cyprian** shaped Christian theology there. In the 4th century, King **Ezana of Axum** converted to Christianity, making Ethiopia one of the first Christian kingdoms. The **Coptic Church** in Alexandria became a center of Christian learning and theology. Christianity faced persecution from Roman authorities and later competition from Islam in North Africa, but it remained strong in Ethiopia and Egypt.

3.2.6. Growth of Christianity in Rwanda

Christianity came much later to Rwanda, introduced in **1900** by Catholic missionaries known as the **White Fathers (Missionaries of Africa)**. German and Belgian colonial authorities favored Christianity, which helped it spread quickly. Missionaries built **schools, hospitals, and churches**, preached the Gospel, and baptized converts. Protestant missionaries also arrived in 1907, establishing their own communities. Christianity faced resistance from **traditional Rwandan beliefs** and competition from **Islam**, which had entered Rwanda through traders. Christianity influenced Rwanda's **education, health, politics, and culture**, becoming the dominant religion in the country.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 3.2

In pairs or small groups discuss and relate courage of early Christians to today's Christians challenges.

3.3. Worldwide Christian missions and their development in Africa and Rwanda



Learning activity 3.3

Read about Jesus methodology when assigning the mission:

Jesus sent his disciples out in pairs (two by two) on missions to preach the Gospel, heal the sick, and cast out demons, first with the Twelve Apostles (Mark 6) and later with a larger group of seventy-two others (Luke 10), and finally with the eleven (Mathew 28: 16-20) giving them authority but instructing them to rely on values of hospitality and kindness.

Questions:

1. In a simple sentence, what is the global mission left by Jesus to his believers, especially the Apostles
2. What do you understand by the Great Commission in Christianity?

3.3.1. Worldwide Christian mission

Worldwide Christian missions are efforts by Christians to share the teachings of Jesus Christ with people in different regions of the world. The main goal of these missions was to spread the Christian faith, teach moral values, and help improve communities. Missionaries carried out this work through preaching, establishing churches, schools, and hospitals, and translating the Bible into local languages. After the time of Jesus, the Apostles began spreading Christianity across the Roman Empire, and later, between the 15th and 19th centuries, European missionaries traveled to Africa, Asia, and the Americas. Some of the notable missionary groups included the Jesuits, Franciscans, and Protestant denominations such as Lutherans and Anglicans.

3.3.2. Christian mission in Africa

Christian missions arrived in Africa at different stages. Portuguese missionaries were the first to come in the 15th century, mainly to West and Central Africa. Later, in the 19th century, British, French, and German missionaries arrived and expanded their work. They focused on education, health, and spreading the Christian faith. Their impact was significant: they built schools and hospitals, introduced literacy by translating the Bible into local languages, and encouraged moral and social values in the communities they served.

3.3.3. Spread of Christianity

The spread of Christianity was accomplished through the efforts of the Apostles, who traveled across the Roman Empire, taking the message of Jesus from Jerusalem to other regions. Paul, also known as Saul of Tarsus and the apostle of the Gentiles, played a key role in spreading Christianity in Europe and Asia Minor. Over time, missionaries carried the faith to Africa, Asia, and the Americas. They used several methods, including preaching, building schools and hospitals, translating the Bible into local languages, and providing social services to communities. As a result, Christianity grew globally, influencing culture, mentalities, and ways of living, while also contributing to education and governance.

3.3.4. Growth of Christianity mission in Rwanda

- Christianity was introduced to Rwanda by Catholic missionaries in 1900. The missionaries initially entered Rwanda through Shangi, in the western part of the country. The first Catholic mission was established at Save, in present-day Gisagara District, on 8 August 1900. Other Catholic missions were subsequently established at Zaza on 1 November 1900, Nyundo on 25 April 1901, Rwaza on 20 November 1903, Mibirizi on 20 December 1903, Kabgayi on 20 January 1906, Rulindo on 26 April 1909, Murunda on 17 May 1909, and Kansi on 13 December 1910).

- **Islam** predates Christian missions. It primarily arrived through Arab and Swahili Muslim traders from East Africa (19th-20th century) around 1901, but their first **mosque** or **Masjid al-Fatah** was established by **1913 at Nyamirambo in Kigali**
- Lutheran missionaries arrived later (1907) at Kirinda, Karongi
- then Adventists (1919) at Gitwe, Ruhango
- Association of Baptists (1964) in Rubavu and Musanze
- Anglicans arrived in Rwanda in the early twentieth century, with missions including Gahini and Kigeme.
- Gahini (Eastern Rwanda): The site of the first formal mission station established by Captain Geoffrey Holmes in 1925, where the first baptisms occurred in 1926.
- Kigeme (Southern Rwanda): Another key early mission started by Geoffrey Holmes in 1931.
- With Methodists arriving later (around 1942) at Kibogora, Nyamasheke.

Mission Activities in Rwanda are: Established churches, schools, and hospitals, promoted literacy and moral education, and they still have impacts: Christianity is a major religion in Rwanda, Rwandan cultures, education, health sector, community development were influenced



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 3.3

1. When did the 1st Christian message arrive in Rwanda
2. What do you understand by Coptic churches? Name 2 countries where we find them
3. When was the first Muslim Mosque built in Rwanda? Where exactly?
4. When do Lutherans and Adventists arrive in Rwanda?
5. How did Christian mission transform Africans' lives?

3.4. Meaning and Importance of Da'wah (inviting to Islam) with Qualities of a Caller to Islam (patience, wisdom, kindness)



Learning activity 3.4

You are one of the investors in the private sector that is organizing an exhibition of agriculture products which will take place in Kigali city.

1. Suggest all possible methods or strategies you will use to mobilize the people from Kigali city to attend your exhibition
2. Use the available resources to identify the means used by the Islamic pillars to expand this religion around the world.

3.4.1. Meaning of Da'wah

In Islam, Da'wah (دعوة) means the act of "calling" or "inviting" people to understand, embrace, and practice Islam. It is rooted in the Quran and Prophet Muhammad's mission to call humanity to the worship of Allah: "Invite to the way of your Lord with wisdom and good instruction." (Surah An-Nahl 16:125). It's a fundamental duty for Muslims, encompassing sharing the message of monotheism, educating about Islamic values, and guiding others to live righteously, using wisdom, good advice, and gentle dialogue.

Qualities of a caller in da'wah

By act of calling in Islam (Da'wah), a caller should fulfill the following qualities: **sincerity** (Seeking Allah's pleasure, not fame or argument), **knowledge, wisdom** (hikmah), **kindness** (Lutf), **patience** (Sabr), and **good character**, acting as a **living example of the faith**, using **gentleness** (rifq), avoiding harshness, and relying on Allah (SWT). He/she must possess deep faith, understand the message, and apply Islamic morals like humility, truthfulness, and mercy in his/her actions.

Importance of Da'wah in Islam

Da'wah is crucial because:

- It helps people to learn about Islam and its teachings.
- It guides people to live morally upright lives.
- It strengthens the Muslim community.
- It preserves the religion for future generations.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 3.4

1. Define Da'wah
2. Explain two ways Da'wah is important in a Muslim's life.
3. List three qualities of a good caller to Islam
4. Quote one Qur'anic verse that teaches Muslims to invite others to worship Allah.
5. How is Da'wah important to the caller himself/herself?

3.5. Methods of Da'wah used by the Prophet Muhammad,



Learning activity 3.5

You are supposed to be sent by Imam in a certain province of Rwanda to make an Islamic Da'wah. Suggest any 5 qualities you will wear or methods you will use for a successful calling.

When Muhammad performed Da'wah, he focused on Tawhid (the oneness of God) as a central message (confess the oneness of God, ultimate Authority) as the central message. He was guided by **core principles or qualities** like:

- **Building community and education** (like sending teachers)
- **Modeling good character and persuasive dialogue** while establishing societal structures in Medina,
- **Use a systemic social guidance**, rather than force.
- **Gentleness & Love** (Rifq & Mawaddah): He addressed people with polite language, compassion, love, and kindness, avoided harshness or anger even towards opponents, emphasizing his role as a mercy to mankind.
- **Wisdom & Good Counsel** (Hikmah): He used logic, clear communication, and tailored his message to the understanding of his audience, often starting with foundational concepts.
- **Patience and Steadfastness** (Sabr): Despite opposition, he remained firm on principles, patiently enduring hardship and refusal, never compromising core tenets.
- **Leading by Example** (Action): His life was a living demonstration of Islamic teachings, acting according to his words, making him a powerful role model.

The Core methods and strategies for a Da'wah in Islam:



The Prophet's da'wah was holistic: He transmitted strong principles using simple and adaptable methods which were basically deeply rooted in love, wisdom, and a personal commitment to God's message. Those **methods** are:

- **Direct and Personal Communication (individual approach)**: Face-to-face dialogue, secret invitations early on, and public addresses, like from Mount Safa, to engage people directly.
- **Community building (Medina)**: Established mosques, united different groups (Muhajirin and Ansar), and created societal frameworks like the Medina Charter to build a functioning Islamic society.
- **Education and mentorship**: Sent companions like Mus'ab ibn Umair as ambassadors to teach the Quran and Islam in new areas.
- **Non-confrontation**: Spread Islam peacefully, non-violent approach

- **Strategic use of location and time:** He chose locations like Mount Safa for public announcements and engage people during pilgrimage seasons to reach wider audiences.
- **Reflection on nature and signs:** Encouraged reflection on the universe (creation) as signs of Allah.
- **Good character and example:** The Prophet showed honesty, patience, humility, and trustworthiness. Example: People accepted Islam, seeing his character.
- **Storytelling and Parables:** Used stories to explain moral lessons and faith principles. Example: Stories of past Prophets to teach patience and obedience.
- **Letters to leaders:** Sent letters to kings and rulers inviting them to Islam politely. Example: Letters to Heraclius, Khosrow, and Negus.
- **Public gatherings:** Invited people during sermons, Friday prayers, and public gatherings



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 3.5

1. Highlight any four behaviors to prevent in Islamic Da'wah
2. What is the central point in Da'wah performance?
3. Explain the importance of Da'wah in Islam

3.6. Importance of Religious Expansion in Modern Society



Learning activity 3.6

Rwanda is striving for advanced development that requires embracing the current global modernism.

1. Prove how Rwanda society is becoming modern
2. How is religious growth important to modern Rwandan society

3.6.1. Description of a modern society

We cannot exhaustively list all the characteristics of modern society, but we obviously mention: industrialization, urbanization, technology, and globalization, shifting from tradition to complex systems where social roles are specialized, interdependence grows, and life centers on market exchange, information, and science rather than rigid customs. The main features include vast interconnectedness, diverse subcultures, a focus on education, dynamic institutions (government, media, education), and individuals defined by specialized jobs and consumption, leading to both opportunity and new challenges like social stratification or classification, and rapid transformations

3.6.2. Ways of extending religion in modern society

Formerly, the key means of religious growth were preaching by covering long distances and face-to-face mobilization. Today, the distance and the vast distances are no longer serious issues; modern technology has reduced the effects of distance. We should use both the existing way of religious diffusion and implement the adaptive methods to easily reach modern society. **Some of them are:**

- **Media:** TV, radio, social media, podcasts, blogs.
- **Education:** Schools, universities, workshops, seminars.
- **Community outreach:** Volunteering, charitable work, public lectures.
- **Interfaith dialogue:** Promotes mutual understanding and respect.
- **Digital tools:** Apps, online Qur'an/Bible study, e-learning platforms.

3.6.3. Importance/impacts of religious expansion in modern society

In modern society, despite the spiritual piety regression, religion remains a powerful force to shape personal identity and spiritual life. Through shared beliefs, rituals, and community, believers strengthen their unity, morals, and social cohesion. Religion also influences politics, culture, and public policy, though it faces challenges and transformations due to globalization, secularism, and technology that lead to both increased diversity and new forms of religious expression. It provides meaning, well-being, and programs for addressing issues like inequality and violence. However, it also interconnects with debates on human rights, democracy, and acts as a source of both stability and social change.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 3.6

1. Answer the following questions with **True** or **False**
 - a) Religious expansion is only made by covering the geographical territories.
 - b) Social media cannot be used to spread religious knowledge.
 - c) The religious social media wrongly used can build social unity
 - d) Religious education in schools does not affect moral behavior.
 - e) Interfaith dialogue can help reduce misunderstandings and conflicts.
2. By science and technology, you can find solutions to your problem; religion is not necessary for you. Discuss and contrast.



END OF UNIT ASSESSMENT 3

PART A: KNOWLEDGE AND UNDERSTANDING

1. What is the meaning of religious expansion?
2. After you read the statement, respond with **True** or **False**
 - a) Christianity began in the Roman-era Middle East,
 - b) the first Muslim community was established in Medina after the Hijrah
 - c) When Muhammad PBUH announced Islam, the whole population supported him,
 - d) When Jesus started teaching in his native area, the population was totally convinced
3. What is Da'wah, and why is it important for Muslims to invite others to Islam?
4. Based on Muhammad's Da'wah, what is the central point of calling?

PART B: SKILLS

5. Explain the importance of spiritual life to a modern society
6. Match the items in Column **A** with the answers in Column **B**

Column A	Column B
A1. Early methods used by Islam and Christianity to spread their teachings	B1. Legalized Christianity shaped doctrines, organized the church structure, and ended persecution
A2. Effects of persecution and martyrdom on early Christianity	B2. Establishing schools/hospitals and translating scriptures, teaching new believers
A3. Influence of leaders like Emperor Constantine and early church fathers	B3. Missionary preaching, trade networks, the use of local languages, and the building of worship centers
A4. Methods used by missionaries to spread Christianity to new regions	B4. Inspired more converts, strengthened believers' faith, and increased public attention to Christianity

Assess the tangible impacts of religious expansion on Rwandan society.

PART C: ATTITUDES & VALUES

1. How is religious education helping you to live with others?
2. From the religious meaning of Jihad, what are you going to strive for?
3. The Bible says, "When someone slaps your one cheek, turn the other too" Matthew 5:39–40. Find out three positive attitudes/values from the given quote.

UNIT IV:

REPENTANCE, FORGIVENESS AND RECONCILIATION



Key unit competence

Learners will be able to analyse the importance of repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation in restoring relationships with God and others, and apply these values in promoting peace, unity and social harmony in their daily lives and Rwandan community.

Learning outcomes

By the end of the unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Define repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation
- Explain their importance for individuals and communities.
- Describe Christian teachings on repentance and forgiveness.

Skills

- Identify situations that require repentance and reconciliation.
- Interpret the symbols of baptism (water, candle, white garment)
- Identify steps to seek Allah's forgiveness.
- Suggest ways youth can promote peace.

Attitude and values

- Participate actively in the activities understanding toward others.
- Value Allah's mercy and forgiveness in daily conduct.

INTRODUCTION

In this unit, we explore the meaning of repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation in both Christianity and Islam. Learners will understand how these practices restore relationships, promote peace, and reflect God's mercy. We will also study baptism and its symbols, as well as Islamic teachings on Tawbah (Repentance) and Maghfirah (forgiveness from God). Through real-life examples, students will learn the importance of forgiving others, resolving conflicts peacefully, and building unity in their communities.



Introductory activity

Read the following paragraph carefully:

Rwanda's politics of unity and reconciliation post-1994 genocide against Tutsi centers on building a common Rwandan identity, promoting equal rights, and fostering social cohesion through strong government policies. The journey started by applying community-based Gacaca courts where criminals confessed and asked for forgiveness to their committed sins. The politics of unity and reconciliation urges the offended side to forgive as one of possible methods of getting inner peace and reaching sustainable reconciliation. These efforts have contributed to reconciliation, the general and fundamental value is Ndi Umunyarwanda and the country is clearly developing.

Questions:

1. Genocide perpetrators who accept responsibility and tell the truth. Highlight any two benefits for both sides (Offender and offended)
2. Explain any two roles of forgiving according to the above paragraph
3. The reconciliation process includes repentance and forgiveness. Justify the general importance of reconciliation to society within different religions.

4.1. Meaning and importance of repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation in society



Learning activity 4.1

Observe the picture above and answer the following questions.



After conflict; relationship is restored

1. Describe the situation on the image above
2. Compare the appearance of the same people in both images
3. How does repentance help repair broken relationships in school or in society?
4. How can forgiveness bring peace in families, schools, and even in Rwanda as a nation?

4.1.1. Meaning and importance

1. Repentance

Repentance is the sincere turning away from sin and wrong actions, with regret for the past and a decision to change behavior. It involves admitting mistakes and choosing to live rightly.

Example: After the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, many people who committed crimes had to repent by confessing their actions before *Gacaca courts* (community-based justice).

2. Forgiveness

Forgiveness is letting go of anger, resentment, or the desire for revenge against someone who has wronged you. It is an act of mercy and love.

Example: Many genocide survivors forgave perpetrators, even those who killed their family members, to promote peace and unity.

3. Reconciliation

Reconciliation is the process of restoring friendship and harmony after conflict. It is the result of repentance and forgiveness working together.

Example: Rwanda has national programs like *Ndi Umunyarwanda* ("I am Rwandan"), which encourage dialogue, unity, and reconciliation among citizens.

How They Work Together

Repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation work together as a complete process of restoring broken relationships. Repentance begins the journey by admitting wrongs and showing a sincere desire to change. Forgiveness follows, removing bitterness and granting mercy to the offender. Finally, reconciliation completes the process by bringing back peace, harmony, and trust between people. In the Rwandan community, this process has been especially important after the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. Perpetrators repented by confessing their crimes, survivors forgave by letting go of anger and resentment, and reconciliation allowed communities to rebuild trust and live together peacefully. This shows that true healing and unity are possible when repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation are practiced together.

4.1.2. Concept of sin in Christianity and Islam

a) Sin in Christianity:

Biblically, sin refers to a **transgression (breaking) of God's law**, rebellion, or acting lawlessly (**1 John 3:4**). It incorporates **sins of commission** (doing an evil) and **sins of omission** (failing to do what is right). Sin differs from evil by human intention, then Sin will be defined as **a deliberate act (intentional), thought, or desire** that violates God's will or human conscience, leading to separation from God and to eternal death as spiritual effect (**Romans 6:23**). Out of religion, it also means a serious fault or regrettable action. evil refers to wrongdoing, which may be intentional or unintentional

b) Sin in Islam

Similarly in Islam, a sin Dhanb is any act of disobedience or transgression against Allah's laws as we find it in the Quran (Surah Al-Ma'idah 5:2: do not cooperate in sin and transgression) and Sunnah (Prophet Muhammad's practices and teachings). It's a deviation from inborn righteousness (fitrah) and involves willful insubordination or neglecting obligations, leading to negative consequences, but Islam emphasizes Allah's immense mercy, forgiveness (Tawbah) and the human capacity for spiritual growth, distinguishing between lesser and major sins like shirk(sin of idolatry) or murdering

4.1.3. Importance of repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation

Introduction

Repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation are three interconnected values that play a vital role in restoring relationships with God, oneself, and the community. Both the **Bible** and the **Qur'an** emphasize their spiritual importance, while the Rwandan community provides powerful examples of their social significance, especially in the aftermath of the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. By examining these values, learners can understand how they bring peace with God, inner healing, and unity among people.

Concept	Spiritual Importance (Relation with God)	Personal Importance (Inner life)	Social Importance (Community life)
Repentance	Restores relationship with God by admitting sins and seeking His mercy. Bible: In Luke 15:11–32 (Parable of the Prodigal Son), the son repents and returns to his father, showing how repentance restores relationship with God. Qur'an: Surah Az-Zumar 39:53 – “Do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed, Allah forgives all sins.” Repentance brings God's forgiveness.	Brings peace of mind, freedom from guilt, and moral growth.	Encourages honesty, responsibility, and trust among people. Example: After the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, perpetrators repented by confessing their crimes in <i>Gacaca courts</i> . This helped communities face the truth and begin healing

Forgiveness	Reflects God's mercy, since He forgives those who forgive others. Bible: In Matthew 18:21-22, Jesus teaches Peter to forgive "seventy times seven," showing forgiveness is endless and divine. Qur'an: Surah Ash-Shura 42:40 – <i>"The recompense of an injury is an injury equal thereto; but if a person forgives and makes reconciliation, his reward is due from Allah."</i>	Heals emotional wounds, reduces anger, and promotes inner peace.	Prevents revenge, promotes unity, and strengthens friendships and family ties. Example: Survivors of the genocide forgave perpetrators, even those who harmed their families, to prevent revenge and promote peace. This forgiveness allowed communities to live together again.
Reconciliation	Restores harmony with God, showing obedience to His will of peace. Bible: In 2 Corinthians 5:18 – <i>"God reconciled us to Himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation."</i> Qur'an: Surah Al-Hujurat 49:10 – <i>"The believers are but brothers, so make settlement between your brothers."</i> Reconciliation is a duty to restore peace.	Gives joy, hope, and a sense of belonging.	Builds national unity, heals divisions (e.g., post-genocide Rwanda), and promotes cooperation. Example: Rwanda's <i>Ndi Umunyarwanda</i> program encourages dialogue and unity, helping citizens reconcile and rebuild trust. This has strengthened national unity and social harmony.

Repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation are essential pillars of spiritual life and social harmony. Spiritually, they reconnect believers with God; personally, they bring peace of mind and emotional healing; and socially, they rebuild trust and unity within communities, as seen in Rwanda's journey of healing through *Gacaca courts* and the *Ndi Umunyarwanda* program. Together, these values show that true peace and restored relationships are possible when individuals sincerely repent, others forgive, and communities reconcile.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 4.1

Writing Activity: "Peace in Our School"

Instructions for Learners

Think of a situation in school, family, or community where someone made a mistake (e.g., fighting, gossiping, breaking rules, or disrespecting others).

Write a short story (about 1–2 paragraphs) that shows:

1. **Repentance:** The person admits their mistake and says sorry.
2. **Forgiveness:** The other person accepts the apology and lets go of anger.
3. **Reconciliation:** Both restore their relationship and live peacefully again.
 - **Give your story a title** that reflects peace or unity (e.g., *"The Apology That Brought Us Together"*).
 - **End your story with a lesson** about why repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation are important in society, especially in Rwanda.

4.2. Repentance and Forgiveness in Christianity

4.2.1. Repentance in Christianity



Learning activity 4.2

Read the **Parable of the Prodigal Son (Luke 15:11–32)**.

1. What mistake did the younger son make when he left his father's house?
2. How did the father respond when his son came back? What does this teach us about God's forgiveness toward sinners?
3. How does reconciliation restore peace in families, schools, and communities?
4. What would happen if people refused to repent, forgive, or reconcile?

Biblically, human disobedience (Eating the fruits of the forbidden Tree) started by the first human created by God (Genesis chapter 3). The result became shame and hiding, and expulsion from Eden (loss of happiness). **Ecclesiastes 7:20 says "There is not a righteous person on earth who always does good and never sins". The New Testament also confirms "If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves 1 John 1:8 the same in Romans 3:23"all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God".**

The Bible and Christian teachings underscored the necessity of repentance urge believers to do so as essential for salvation and God's favor: In Psalm 51 we find King David's heartfelt prayer for forgiveness after his sin with Bathsheba and murder of Uriah, expressing deep remorse and asking God for cleansing, a pure heart, and a renewed spirit. Matthew 4:17 «Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand», **Acts 2:38** "repent and be baptized", Luke 13:3 "Unless you repent, you will all likewise perish", 2 Chronicles 7:14 "turn from wicked ways for healing".

Phases to true repentance in Christianity

God loves the sinner who repents (Luke 15:11-32: parable of the lost son) and all sins are forgiven (Matthew 12:31-32). To repent **is not just to confess** sins but a **transformative process** including accepting your sin, feeling genuine sorrow (remorse), confessing it to God (and others if needed), forsaking the sin (stopping the behavior), and resolving not to repeat it, often requiring active steps like restitution and turning towards God for change.

The key phases of repentance that lead to a new direction Christian life are

- **conviction/recognition (Acceptance of sins)**
- **regret/remorse (feeling sorrow of sins)**
- **confession (in secret: John 8:1-11 or publicly: James 5:16; Acts 19, Mark 1:4-4:18; individually or collectively)**
- **forsaking/stopping (decision of total abandonment or renunciation of sins)**
- **Resolution/reformation: actively make restitution, and commit to living a changed, righteous life (reformation),** doing good and living right, often. The repentant should demonstrate a permanent shift in heart and behavior.

4.2.2. Forgiveness in Christianity

The Christian meaning of forgiveness is to release others from the debt of their sins, letting go of resentment (anger), and choosing grace and mercy, copying how God forgives believers through Christ's sacrifice. Forgiveness is a sign of love (Luke 23:34), mercy on others is a gift or grace of God then all believers are called imitate God's mercy (Ephesians 4:32; Luke 6:36).

Forgiveness is a Christian duty and is linked to forgiving others (Matthew 6:14-15)

The common stages for forgiveness are:

- Uncovering: recognizing the hurt/acknowledging hurt
- Decision: reached through processing the hurt
- Work: bearing pain and work for healing
- Deepening: finding meaning, growth and gain inner peace
- Empathy: choosing to let go
- Release: express the decision to release the grievance
- Renewal: changes to renew relationship

The effects of forgiveness in Christianity

- Harmony in families, in church and community at large
- Emotional healing, inner peace and security.
- Love, unity and solidarity in the society
- social cohesion, collaboration, and development of society



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 4.2

1. Act out the *Parable of the Prodigal Son* where one student plays the father, another the son, and others as observers. And after the role play, **discuss** how repentance and forgiveness restored their relationship.
2. Present a school conflict (e.g., two classmates fighting). And ask learners to **analyze** how repentance and forgiveness could solve the problem.
3. In groups, **share** examples of forgiveness in families, schools, or Rwanda's reconciliation after the genocide. And **explain** how these examples promote peace and unity.
4. Ask learners to **write** a short paragraph about a time they asked for forgiveness or forgave someone, and how it changed the relationship.
5. Give verses like Matthew 6:12 or Luke 23:34. And **discuss** how these verses guide Christians to practice repentance and forgiveness in daily life.

4.3. BAPTISM IN CHRISTIANITY



Learning activity 4.3

Observe carefully the image below and answer the questions that follow:



1. What do you learn about baptism from observing the picture?
2. How does baptism teach Christians to live peacefully, forgive others, and maintain unity.

Meaning of Baptism

The word baptism comes from the Greek verb baptizō, meaning to immerse or dip, which means “washing, dipping, or immersing in water.” It is a rite of purification and consecration that marks the beginning of a believer's new life in Christ. More than just a ritual, baptism is a public declaration of faith and obedience to God.

Baptism is a Christian sacrament that shows a person's entry into the Christian family and symbolizes the beginning of a new life in Christ. Through baptism, Christians become one family, united in Christ regardless of their differences. It teaches them to love one another, to live in unity, and to share peace and respect within the Christian community.

Symbols used in Baptism in Christianity and their significance

In Christian baptism, several symbols are used in baptism, and each has an important meaning. Water is the most important symbol; it signifies washing away of sins, purification, and spiritual rebirth, showing that the baptized person starts a new life in Christ. The white garment worn after baptism represents purity, innocence, and a clean life without sin, showing that the person has been symbolizes new life. Oil (Holy oil or Chrism) is used to anoint the baptized person; it signifies strength from the Holy Spirit, healing, and being chosen by God, showing that the person is set apart for God's service. The candle or light, lit from the Paschal candle, symbolizes Christ as the Light of the world, guidance, and living in truth, reminding Christians to live as children of light. Finally, in traditions that use it, the sign of the cross is made on the baptized person; it signifies belonging to Christ, salvation through Jesus' death on the cross, and protection by God, showing that the person is now a follower of Christ. Before baptism, a person repents and turns away from sin. God then forgives the person, and the broken relationship with God is restored through reconciliation. Through baptism, the person joins a united Christian community. This unity teaches Christians to live peacefully, respect others, and help one another in their daily lives.

The Importance of Baptism in the Unity of Repentance, Forgiveness, and Reconciliation

We study Baptism in Christianity in the unity of repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation because baptism is directly connected to all these teachings in Christianity. Baptism comes after repentance, when a person turns away from sin. It reminds Christians that their past sins are washed away and that they are given a new beginning. Baptism also symbolizes reconciliation between human beings and God, and it supports reconciliation not only with God but also with other people. Studying baptism in this unity helps learners link Christian religious teachings to real life behaviors such as forgiveness, unity, and peaceful living with others.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 4.3

1. What is the meaning of baptism?
2. How does baptism show that a person has started a new life in Christ?
3. Explain the significance of each symbol:
 - a) Water
 - b) White garment
 - c) Oil (Holy oil / Chrism)
 - d) Candle / Light
 - e) Sign of the cross

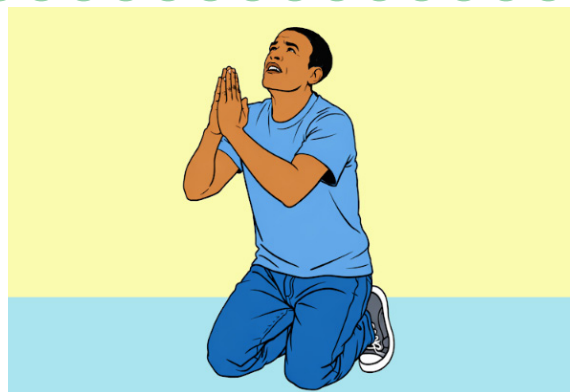
4. In what ways does baptism help a person reconcile with God and other people?
5. How does studying baptism help learners practice forgiveness and reconciliation in their daily lives?
6. Give one example of how a baptized person can show repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation in school or at home.

4.4. Repentance and Forgiveness in Islam



Learning activity 4.4

Observe carefully the image below and answer the questions that follow:



He implores divine pardon for his sins

1. What is the person in the picture doing?
2. What is the Islamic meaning of turning back?
3. What do you understand by Tawbah?
4. Identify the importance of Tawbah/repentance.

The holy Qur'an clearly teaches the necessity of repentance (Tawbah), the love and mercy of Allah towards sinners and the benefits for the ones who repent. Let us explore some Qur'anic surah:

1. "O My servants who have transgressed against themselves [by sinning], do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed, Allah forgives all sins. Truly, He is the Most Forgiving, the Most Merciful." Surah Az-Zumar (39:53)

2. Allah accepts the repentance of those who do evil in ignorance and repent soon after; it is they to whom Allah will turn in forgiveness. And Allah is All-Knowing, All-Wise. Surah An-Nisa (4:17).

Allah speaks directly to sinners with love and hope. Even if a person has committed many sins; Allah's mercy is greater than them all. In Islamic theology, dying without repentance from **shirk** is described as unforgivable (**associating partners with Allah**). Muslims are encouraged to **never lose hope**, but to repent sincerely.

Allah accepts repentance when it is done sincerely and without delay. The verse teaches that repentance must be immediate before death and before seeing the punishment of Allah.

Meaning of Repentance (Tawbah)

a) Ignorance in Islam (Jahl)

In Islam, ignorance (Jahl) or lack of knowledge is seen as a state that leads to wrongdoing, harming oneself and others, and is actively discouraged, contrasting sharply with the pursuit of knowledge (**ilm**) as a path to piety, understanding Allah's signs (Quran, universe), and fulfilling duties in belief, worship, and character. The following are the examples of jahl actions: family violence, corpse mutilation, and oppressing the weak, pride with **Surah Al-'Alaq** (Chapter 96) directly reproaching arrogance and pride

b) Meaning of sin in Islam

In Islam, sin (dhanb/khaṭī'ah) is any deliberate act violating Allah's commands.

Categories of sins in Islam: two main categories are:

- **Major sins** (kaba'ir) like shirk (associating partners with God), murder, theft, adultery, or consuming riba (interest: any unjustified increase or excess in financial transactions, especially charging extra money on loans or delayed payments, which is strictly forbidden (haram).
- **Minor sins** (Lamam): gossiping, backbiting, minor lying, wasting water/food, breaking small promises, impatience, or looking at forbidden things. They do not have punishment in the Quran; and they are forgiven by good deeds like prayer and remembrance, but still must be avoided as they can lead to major sins.

c) Understanding Tawbah

It makes Allah happy when a sinner truly repents: "Indeed, Allah loves those who repent" (Al-Baqarah 2:222). The Islamic meaning of repentance (Tawbah) is to sincerely return to Allah after sinning and never return to sin, that means to stop the transgression, feeling deep regret, resolve never to repeat it, and restore rights if others were involved, with the purpose of purification and pleasing God, transforming sins into good deeds through sincere turning back to Allah. Tawbah is a fundamental spiritual act, involving **genuine remorse** and **commitment to righteous living**, not just rituals. Similarly, in Christianity, a true repentance requires a connection between intention, decision, words and actions

d) A Muslim attitude in Tawbah

A Muslim in repentance (Tawbah) should turn back to Allah after he/she finds out a sin was committed by feeling a spiritual regret and immediate commitment to stop wrongdoing and never to repeat it. She/he is seeking forgiveness, which involves making compensations if another person was harmed and he/she does it in the spiritual state of trusting in Allah's immense mercy and forgiveness.

4.4.2. Conditions for Sincere Repentance in Islam

Regret: Feeling sincere sorrow and shame for committing the sin.

- **Immediate Cessation:** Stopping the sin immediately once realizing it is wrong.
- **Firm Resolution:** Making a strong decision not to return to the sin again.
- **Restitution:** If the sin involves the rights of others, those rights must be returned or forgiven.
(e.g., returning stolen property or asking forgiveness).
- **Repent before death and before seeing punishment:** True repentance must happen before the soul reaches the throat. Because **"Allah accepts the repentance of those who do evil in ignorance and repent soon after"** (Surah An-Nisa 4:17)

4.4. 3. Importance of repentance in Islam

- It cleanses the soul from sins (it brings inner peace)
- It strengthens the relationship between a believer and Allah (Horizontal and vertical relationship).
- Allah loves those who repent sincerely (Forgiveness and blessings) as the Quran confirms: **"Indeed, Allah loves those who repent and purify themselves."** (Surah Al-Baqarah 2:222)



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 4.4

1. Highlight the steps a Muslim passes through for a complete repentance
2. What should a Muslim fulfil for repentance to be considered sincere?
3. Give any four examples of big sins in Islam
4. What does turn back to Allah symbolize in Islam?
5. How do you behave after repenting?

4.5. Importance of Repentance, Forgiveness, and Reconciliation in Modern Society



Learning activity 4.5

Observe the images below and give answers to the given questions about them.



1. Describe the situation on the images above.
2. Are the cases often occurring in the traditional or modern area?
3. Identify the Emotional, financial, social and religious effects of those behaviors.
4. Give pieces of advice for the practitioners of those behaviors.

4.5.1. Definition of Modern Society

Modern society is a way of life where people use new ideas, science, and technology to improve how they live. It is different from traditional society because it focuses on development, education, equality, and peace.

One side modernism brings significant positives like technological innovation, social progress, and new forms of expression. It supported progress, science, and human potential. **On the other side**, it also brings negatives such as disaffection, loss of tradition, cultural homogenization, creating anxiety, a sense of cultural crisis and increased individualism that can contribute to superficiality or conflict.

The religious perspective considers the following modern behaviors as sins: sexual lust and prostitution, greed through gambling and consumerism, wrath (violence), sloth (sedentary lifestyles), and gluttony (fast food, obesity), alongside newer manifestations such as rampant vanity (cosmetic surgery), excessive individualism, digital addiction, kidnapping, human trafficking, and social injustices like inequality.

Description of Modern Society in Rwanda People live in towns and cities like Kigali with modern houses, roads, and electricity. Technology is used daily, such as mobile phones, internet, and mobile money. Education is valued, with schools and universities preparing learners for modern jobs.

- Gender equality is promoted, with women and men sharing leadership roles (Rwanda has substantial representation of women in Parliament).
- Unity and reconciliation are important after the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, helping Rwandans live peacefully together.
- Economic growth is seen in programs like *Vision 2020* and *Vision 2050*, aiming to make Rwanda a middle-income country.

4.5.2. The necessity of repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation in modern societies

Repentance

Repentance in Christianity and Islam means turning away from sin and returning sincerely to God or Allah. In Christianity, the Bible says, "Repent, then, and turn to God, so that your sins may be wiped out" (Acts 3:19). Repentance today is seen when someone admits wrongdoing—like a student confessing to cheating, a neighbor returning a lost item, or a leader apologizing for corruption—and chooses to live honestly. Just as the Prodigal Son returned to his father (Luke 15:11–32), repentance restores relationships and helps individuals grow morally and spiritually. In Islam, repentance, called Tawbah, also involves feeling regret for sin, asking Allah for forgiveness, and making a strong intention not to repeat it. The Qur'an teaches, "And those who, when they commit an immorality or wrong themselves, remember Allah and seek forgiveness for their sins—and who can forgive sins except Allah?—and do not persist in what they did while they know" (Qur'an 3:135). In daily life, Tawbah can be seen when a student admits lying, a person stops cheating, helps a neighbor in need, or someone seeks to repair relationships. In Rwanda, these practices promote **values and attitudes** such as honesty, humility, respect, forgiveness, and peaceful living in families, schools, and communities. Both Christianity and Islam show that repentance restores one's relationship with God or Allah, encourages moral growth, and helps individuals contribute positively to society

The stages of repentance are:

In Christianity:

1. **Recognition of sin** – Admitting to oneself and God that one has sinned.
2. **Sincere remorse** – Feeling genuine regret for the wrongdoing.
3. **Confession** – Telling God in prayer, and sometimes confessing to a priest or a trusted person.
4. **Decision to change** – Making a firm intention not to repeat the sin.
5. **Amends** – Correcting the harm done, if possible (e.g., returning stolen goods, asking for forgiveness).

In Islam (Tawbah):

1. **Acknowledging the sin** – Realizing the act disobeys Allah.
2. **Feeling remorse** – Feeling regret and sorrow for committing the sin.
3. **Stopping the sin immediately** – Ceasing the sinful action at once.
4. **Seeking forgiveness from Allah** – Praying sincerely and asking Allah to pardon the sin.
5. **Intention not to repeat** – Making a strong commitment to avoid the sin in the future.
6. **Restoring rights of others** – Compensating or apologizing if someone else was harmed.

Forgiveness

Forgiveness in Christianity and Islam means releasing anger, showing mercy, and restoring broken relationships, just as God forgives us. In Christianity, Jesus taught, "Forgive, and you will be forgiven" (Luke 6:37), and forgiveness is seen when neighbors reconcile after a land dispute or friends make peace after a quarrel. Similarly, in Islam, forgiveness, called **'afw (forgiveness/pardoning)**, is highly encouraged; the Qur'an teaches, "Hold to forgiveness; command what is right; but turn away from the ignorant" (Qur'an 7:199), and Muslims practice it by apologizing, reconciling, and stopping harmful behavior. In Rwandan culture, forgiveness is a core value that supports **Ubumwe n'Ubwiyunge**, as people forgive those who cause accidental harm, reconcile after disagreements, and work together for social harmony. By practicing forgiveness, individuals follow religious teachings, promote peace, strengthen unity, and contribute to reconciliation within families, schools, and the wider community.

The stages of forgiveness are:

In Christianity:

1. **Acknowledging the wrongdoing** – The wronged person recognizes what happened.
2. **Decision to forgive** – Choosing to let go of anger and resentment.
3. **Expressing forgiveness** – Saying or showing forgiveness to the wrongdoer.
4. **Restoring trust** – Working to rebuild the relationship if possible.

In Islam:

1. **Recognizing the harm** – Understanding the wrongdoing.
2. **Letting go of anger** – Choosing mercy over revenge.
3. **Reconciling with the person** – Apologizing, forgiving, and making peace.
4. **Seeking Allah's reward** – Remembering that forgiveness is rewarded by Allah.

Reconciliation

Reconciliation means restoring broken relationships and living in harmony. In Christianity, the Bible says, "God... reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation" (2 Corinthians 5:18), and Paul urges believers to be "at peace with everyone" (Romans 12:18). In Islam, reconciliation, called Sulh, is highly valued; the Qur'an teaches, "And if two parties among the believers quarrel, make peace between them" (Qur'an 49:9). Both faiths emphasize dialogue, mercy, and restoring trust. In Rwanda, reconciliation after the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi shows how people can overcome hatred and rebuild unity through dialogue, justice, and shared commitment to peace.

Young Rwandans can practice *Ubumwe n'Ubwiyunge* by applying repentance (admitting and changing wrongs), forgiveness (letting go of anger and showing mercy), and reconciliation (peaceful discussion and agreement) in schools, families, and communities. For example, students can reconcile after arguments, siblings can forgive each other, and youth can participate in unity clubs or community peace initiatives. By following these values from both Christianity and Islam, young people learn to live in harmony, promote social cohesion, and strengthen their identity as Rwandans (*Ndumunyarwanda*), committed to peace, justice, and the well-being of their nation.

The stages of reconciliation are:

In Christianity:

1. **Acknowledgment of conflict** – Recognizing that the relationship is broken.
2. **Repentance** – Both sides admit mistakes and turn away from sin.
3. **Forgiveness** – Letting go of resentment and anger.
4. **Dialogue and understanding** – Talking to clarify issues and rebuild trust.
5. **Restoration of relationship** – Returning to peaceful and cooperative living.

In Islam (Sulh):

1. **Acknowledging the disagreement** – Recognizing conflict exists.
2. **Stopping harmful behavior** – Ceasing the actions that caused harm.
3. **Seeking forgiveness** – Both parties apologize to each other and ask Allah for guidance.
4. **Making peace (Sulh)** – Negotiating, discussing, and agreeing on solutions.
5. **Maintaining harmony** – Working together to restore trust and unity.

Conditions for Genuine Repentance in Christianity

In Christianity, repentance (turning away from sin) is not just saying “sorry” but involves a sincere change of heart and behavior. The main conditions are:

1. **Acknowledging the sin** – The person must admit their wrongdoing and recognize it as against God’s will.
2. **Feeling sincere remorse** – Feeling true regret for the sin committed.
3. **Confession** – Talking to God in prayer, and in some cases, confessing to a priest or others if required.
4. **Decision to change** – Making a firm intention not to repeat the sin.
5. **Making amends** – Correcting the wrong if it harmed someone, such as re-turning stolen items or asking for forgiveness.

The Bible emphasizes this in 1 John 1:9:

"If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

Conditions for Genuine Repentance in Islam (Tawbah)

In Islam, Tawbah also requires sincerity and action. The main conditions are:

- 1. Feeling remorse for the sin** – True regret for disobeying Allah.
- 2. Stopping the sinful act** – Immediately ceasing the wrongdoing.
- 3. Asking Allah for forgiveness** – Praying sincerely for God's pardon.
- 4. Resolving not to repeat the sin** – Making a strong intention to avoid the sin in the future.
- 5. Restoring the rights of others** – If the sin harmed another person, compensating or asking for their forgiveness.

The Role of Religious and Ethics Education in Promoting Repentance, Forgiveness, Reconciliation, and Ubumwe n'Ubwiyunge Among Young Rwandans"

Religious and Ethics Education helps young Rwandans understand the importance of repentance, forgiveness, and reconciliation in modern society, enabling them to face challenges like conflicts, dishonesty, selfishness, and inequality with moral responsibility. In Christianity, repentance is guided by the Bible: "Repent, then, and turn to God, so that your sins may be wiped out" (Acts 3:19), and forgiveness is emphasized: "Forgive, and you will be forgiven" (Luke 6:37). In Islam, repentance (Tawbah) and forgiveness 'afw (forgiveness/pardoning) are taught in the Qur'an: "And those who, when they commit an immorality or wrong themselves, remember Allah and seek forgiveness... and do not persist in what they did while they know" (Qur'an 3:135) and "Hold to forgiveness; command what is right; but turn away from the ignorant" (Qur'an 7:199). To promote sustainable Ubumwe n'Ubwiyunge and being proud Ndumunyarwanda, young people are recommended to: (1) practice honesty and integrity in daily life, (2) forgive those who wrong them and let go of grudges, (3) reconcile and maintain peaceful relationships after conflicts, (4) participate actively in community and unity-building programs, and (5) respect and embrace diversity to strengthen social cohesion and national healing. By applying these values from both Christianity and Islam, young Rwandans become responsible, morally upright citizens, contributing to a united, peaceful, and prosperous society.



APPLICATION ACTIVITY 4.5

1. According to Christianity and Islam, name three modern behaviors considered sinful and explain why they are harmful.
2. Define forgiveness in your own words.
3. How does Christianity teach reconciliation? Give one example from daily life or the Bible.
4. How does Islam teach reconciliation (Sulh)? Give one example from daily life or the Qur'an.
5. Explain how forgiveness is practiced in Rwandan families, schools, or communities. How can young people practice Ubumwe n'Ubwiyunge in schools, families, and communities?



END OF UNIT ASSESSMENT 4

PART A: KNOWLEDGE AND UNDERSTANDING

1. Define **repentance**, **forgiveness**, and **reconciliation**.
2. Recall the conditions for genuine repentance in Christianity and in Islam
3. Mention the stages of forgiveness in Christianity
4. Mention any four examples of Jahl (acts considered as ignorance or lack of knowledge) in Islam and 4 roots of sin in Christianity.
5. List major sins (kaba'ir).
6. Explain what repentance (Tawbah in Islam) is and give one example of how a young person in Rwanda can practice it in school or at home.
7. How does repentance help restore relationships and promote moral growth in modern society?
8. How does Christianity teach forgiveness? Give one example from daily life.
9. How does Islam teach forgiveness 'afw (forgiveness/pardoning)? Give one example from daily life.

PART B: SKILLS

10. Match the elements in A with their corresponding relations in B.

Concept	Explanation
1. Repentance (Tawbah)	a. Builds unity, prevents revenge, promotes trust, peace and harmony, heals the soul and leads to sustainable development
2. Forgiveness	b. Turning away from sin and asking God for forgiveness.
3. Reconciliation	c. Pardoning someone who wronged you, as God forgives us.
4. Importance of repentance, forgiveness and reconciliation	d. Restoring friendship or peace after conflict.

11. Analyze this case of Reconciliation:

One student offended a classmate, later felt remorse, apologized, and asked for reconciliation. The offended student agreed to forgive and reconcile with him but decided never to collaborate with him again.

How does forgiveness help promote Ubumwe n'Ubwiyunge in Rwanda?

PART C: ATTITUDES & VALUES

12. I created good understanding toward others by:

- A. Listening respectfully to others
- B. Refusing to forgive
- C. Starting arguments
- D. Ignoring people's feelings

13. My best way to promote inner peace, good relationship and sustainable development is:

- A. Tolerance, fighting and work
- B. repentance, forgiveness and holding hatred
- C. Insulting those who show apologies
- D. Acceptance of sins, verbal repentance and helping others
- E. Acceptance of sins, intentional repentance and restorative works